Hidden Logic.

The reasons behind what happens at work

76 patterns and 45 scenarios. Each pattern is something you have seen at work, and the reason it happens. Each scenario is a situation where several meet, with what to do. Green marks the patterns that go right, pale green the ones that work both ways.

1.01	1.02	1.03	1.04	1.05	1.06	1.07	2.01	2.02	2.03
2.04	2.05	2.06	2.07	2.08	3.01	3.02	3.03	3.04	3.05
3.06	4.01	4.02	4.03	4.04	4.05	4.06	4.07	4.08	4.09
4.10	4.11	4.12	5.01	5.02	5.03	5.04	5.05	5.06	5.07
5.08	5.09	5.10	5.11	5.12	6.01	6.02	6.03	6.04	6.05
6.06	6.07	6.08	6.09	6.10	6.11	7.01	7.02	7.03	7.04
7.05	7.06	7.07	7.08	7.09	8.01	8.02	8.03	8.04	8.05
8.06	8.07	8.08	8.09	8.10	8.11				

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76 PATTERNS
45 SCENARIOS
8 PARTS
12 SUCCESSES

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Eight parts, 76 patterns, 45 scenarios

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A When you're the manager B Your own career C Pressure from above and around

The book on one page

Why things happen the way they do

The same few forces sit behind most career surprises: trust, risk, visibility, budgets and face.

WHAT YOU SEE		WHAT DRIVES IT	
		What you're told, and what happens 24 things people say at work, set against what you will see.	05
"What I was told isn't what happened"			
"You rose with your boss, then stalled"	**01.**	**Your Boss** Your career moves with your boss: their trust, their fears and their exits.	07
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"Several of these at once, and I have to act"	**S.**	**Scenarios** 45 situations, and whether to fix it, fight, or leave.	42

WHERE THIS BOOK SITS IN THE SERIES

BOOK 1

Framework Thinking

The thinking tools: name a problem, decide, bring people along.

BOOK 2

Kaizen Practice

The team routines: owners, updates, meetings, flow, improvement.

BOOK 3

Hidden Logic

Why things happen between people at work, and what to watch for.

How each pattern reads

Above the line, what you see. Below it, why.

Each pattern is a short card with its diagram, three to a page. One black line, the same line as on the cover, splits it: the situation above, the reason below.

5.01 The Rising Star Penalty

PROBLEM

The top performer was passed over: seen as a flight risk

Simone was the top salesperson in her region three years running, and a rival made her an offer last spring. The regional manager role went to Paul, who had ten steady years.

WHAT DRIVES IT

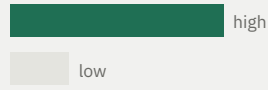
WHY

A promotion is an investment, and bosses invest in people they expect to stay.

WATCH FOR

You win awards, but nobody asks about your next two years.

FLIGHT RISK AS A DECIDER SEES IT



1 **What you see.** The pattern's name, the outcome in plain words, and a two-sentence story with invented names.

2 **Why.** Below the black line: the reason in one sentence. It describes what happens, never what a particular boss was thinking.

3 **Watch for.** One signal you can see before the outcome arrives.

4 **Act with.** The tool in Framework Thinking or the routine in Kaizen Practice, shown only when one fits.

These patterns are common.

Each one has exceptions.

Before you start

What you’re told, and what happens

The things people say at work, and what you will see if you watch. Grouped by the parts of this book.

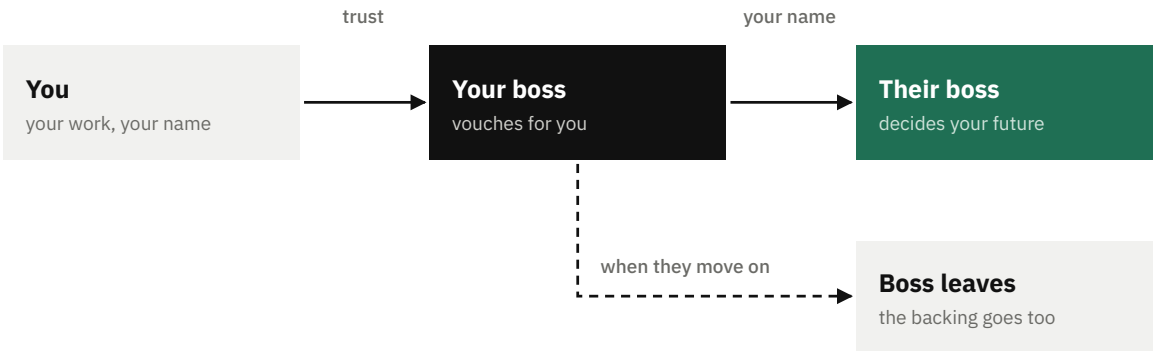
WHAT YOU’RE TOLD	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
01. Your Boss	
“My door is always open.”	**Walk through it with bad news twice, and see.**
“I've got your back.”	**Until backing you costs them something.**
“The new boss will judge everyone fresh.”	**They bring people they already trust, and judge you against them.**
02. The People Around You	
“We're a family here.”	**Until the budget review.**
“Anything you say stays in this room.”	**Assume it reaches someone senior by Friday.**
“Everyone is treated the same.”	**Liked people get a second chance. Others get a process.**
03. Face and Tact	
“We want people who challenge us.”	**In private, politely, and not too often.**
“Feedback is a gift.”	**Feedback to your boss is remembered, and rarely in your favour.**
“Just be honest.”	**Be honest in a way that lets them save face, or pay for it later.**
04. Getting Seen and Getting Credit	
“Your work speaks for itself.”	**Only if someone senior repeats it.**
“We judge on results.”	**They judge on the results they hear about, from people they trust.**
“Office or home, it makes no difference.”	**The people in the room get the good work.**

WHAT YOU'RE TOLD	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
05. Who Gets Promoted	
"We promote on merit."	**People get promoted when someone senior backs them and a budget opens.**
"You're ready. It's just timing."	**There is no role, and nobody is fighting for one.**
"You're high potential."	**You can hear that for years without a promotion.**
06. What You're Worth	
"Loyalty is rewarded."	**Pay rises go to people who might leave.**
"There's no budget this year."	**There's budget for the people they're afraid to lose.**
"Pay follows performance."	**Pay follows what you earned when you joined, and how easily you could leave.**
07. Where Decisions Are Made	
"The meeting will decide."	**The meeting announces what was decided before it.**
"We'll decide based on the data."	**The data gets picked to support what was already decided.**
08. When Things Go Wrong	
"It's a restructure. Nothing personal."	**Who stays was decided by who is liked, and who is cheap.**
"We have an open culture. Raise concerns."	**The messenger gets remembered with the message.**
"You're on a development plan."	**You're on the way out.**
"HR is here for you."	**HR is here for the company.**

01.

Your Boss

Your career moves with your boss: their trust, their fears and their exits.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Personal trust**	1.01 The Sponsor Effect ± · 1.02 The New Boss Reset · 1.05 The Absent Defence ✓ · 1.07 The Coterie
2	**Upward exposure**	1.03 The Successor Threat · 1.04 The Favourite · 1.06 No Surprises ✓
3	**Face**	1.03 The Successor Threat · 1.05 The Absent Defence ✓ · 1.06 No Surprises ✓

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

- Your boss changed, or is about to.
- You hear about decisions in your own area second-hand.
- Your best work reaches the top under someone else's name.

1.01 The Sponsor Effect

± WORKS BOTH WAYS

Your career rose with your boss, then stalled when they left

When Maria's boss became CFO, he made her head of planning. After he left for a competitor, two of her projects moved to other teams.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Your support rests on one person's trust, so it leaves when they leave.

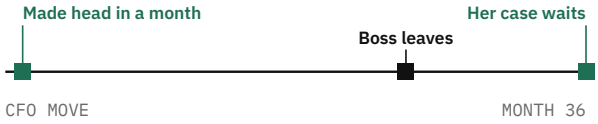
WATCH FOR

Most of your support runs through one person.

ACT WITH

FT 2.06 Power/Interest Grid, to build a second backer before your first one leaves. One backer is a single point of failure.

MARIA'S THREE YEARS FROM THE CFO MOVE



GREEN: THE RISE AND THE STALL. DARK: EVENTS.

1.02 The New Boss Reset

PROBLEM

A new leader arrived and brought their old team

Within a year, the new head of operations had brought in four people from her old company, two into the top jobs. Priya and Marcus, who had run the biggest projects, now reported to them.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A new leader brings people they already trust, because building trust from scratch is slow.

WATCH FOR

Your new boss keeps mentioning people from their last company.

ACT WITH

KP 7.07 One-to-ones, to build a track record with the new boss early, on their priorities.

WHO IS CONSULTED FIRST, LEFT TO RIGHT

BEFORE	Priya	Marcus	Lee	Iris	Raj
SUMMER	Hire 1	Hire 2	Iris	Priya	Marcus

GREEN: HER OLD FIRM. DARK: EXISTING TEAM.

1.03 The Successor Threat

PROBLEM

Your boss feels threatened by you

Dev runs a reporting team. Last spring the COO praised his lead analyst's board pack by name.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Praise from above can make your boss see you as their replacement.

WATCH FOR

Your boss checks what you plan to say upward.

THE ANALYST, BEFORE AND AFTER

BEFORE THE PRAISE	AFTER THE PRAISE
Attends the monthly review	Dev presents all the work
Presents own work	No longer invited

1.04 The Favourite

PROBLEM

Your boss has a favourite, and it isn't you

Lena is consulted first on almost every team decision, including ones about others' work. Two colleagues with stronger results hear of those decisions afterwards, in the team meeting.

WHAT DRIVES IT

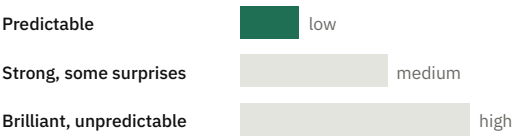
WHY

A boss puts their name behind their people, so they lean on the one who carries least risk.

WATCH FOR

Your results are praised, but you are not asked.

THE BOSS'S RISK IN VOUCHING UPWARD



1.05 The Absent Defence

✓ SUCCESS

Your boss defended you in a meeting you weren't in

In a budget review Tom did not attend, a director asked why his project had overrun. His boss answered before anyone else could.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When a boss defends you, they also defend their own judgement in backing you.

WATCH FOR

Your boss repeats your results to others in your words.

THE SAME OVERRUN, TWO WAYS

WITHOUT A DEFENDER	WITH ONE
Overrun blamed on Tom	Supplier change she approved
Questions asked in his absence	Tom's written flag cited

1.06 No Surprises

✓ SUCCESS

The person who warns the boss early gets more access

Sam told his boss the quarter would miss its numbers by four per cent. His boss's planning session had been kept to two people all year.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Bosses would rather hear bad news early than be surprised in front of their own boss.

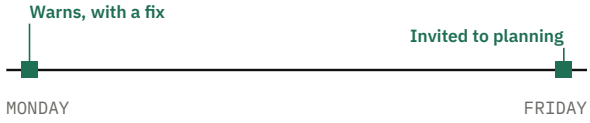
WATCH FOR

Your boss calls you first when something goes wrong.

ACT WITH

KP 3.01 Hōkoku (report early), to make early warning a routine rather than an event.

SAM'S WEEK



GREEN: THE WARNING AND ITS RESULT.

1.07 The Coterie

PROBLEM

A few people around the boss decide what reaches them

The regional director meets her three longest-serving managers every Friday morning. Ideas from anyone else reach her through one of them, and Fiona's proposals arrive a week late, summarised.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A few trusted people around a leader filter what reaches them, and vouch for each other.

WATCH FOR

Your ideas reach the boss through the same few people.

ACT WITH

FT 2.06 Power/Interest Grid, to see who shapes your boss's view and whom you need to reach.

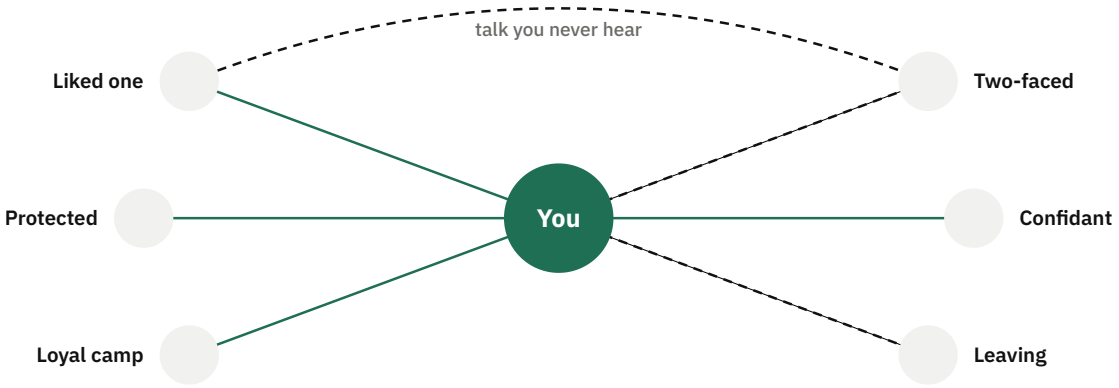
TWO ROUTES TO THE DIRECTOR

INSIDE THE CIRCLE	OUTSIDE IT
Friday meeting with her	Ideas sent through others
Hears plans first	Hears plans afterwards

02.

The People Around You

Colleagues choose, protect and leave for reasons that rarely show in the work.



GREEN: OPEN LINKS. DASHED: CHANNELS YOU CANNOT SEE.

WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Comfort**	2.01 The Likeability Premium · 2.05 The Safe Confidant ✓ · 2.07 Role vs Rapport · 2.08 The Inside Track
2	**Cost of conflict**	2.02 The Two-Faced Colleague · 2.03 The Protected Colleague · 2.04 The Quiet Exit · 2.06 The Loyalty Test
3	**Hidden channels**	2.02 The Two-Faced Colleague · 2.04 The Quiet Exit · 2.05 The Safe Confidant ✓ · 2.08 The Inside Track

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

A less able colleague keeps getting picked over you.

You hear views of yourself that nobody raised with you.

A strong person on your team has gone quiet in meetings.

2.01 The Likeability Premium

PROBLEM

They're less able than you, but everyone wants them on the project

Ana and Joe, two account managers, both asked to join a new client team. Joe's forecasts are less accurate, but colleagues asked for him by name.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When nobody can tell whose work is better, people pick the one they like working with.

WATCH FOR

You are asked for numbers, and they are asked for their view.

THE SAME MISS, READ TWO WAYS

JOE MISSES A FIGURE	ANA MISSES A FIGURE
A hard quarter	Raised in the weekly review
Not mentioned again	Her other numbers rechecked

2.02 The Two-Faced Colleague

PROBLEM

A colleague is friendly to your face and runs you down elsewhere

Kemi in purchasing is warm with Rob in every meeting and praises his supplier work. Then his next renewal is sent to her for checking.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People who avoid open conflict compete behind your back, where you cannot answer.

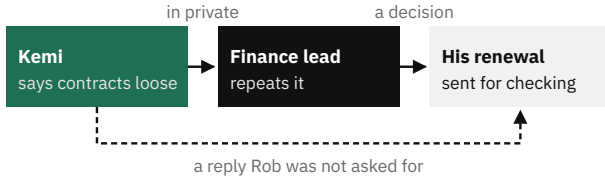
WATCH FOR

People who used to come to you start going to them first.

ACT WITH

FT 6.04 Difficult Conversations, to raise what you have heard with them, before it settles.

HOW ROB'S RENEWAL MOVED



2.03 The Protected Colleague

PROBLEM

The difficult colleague nobody will touch

Gary in the warehouse team shouts at staff and ignores the rota. Three complaints to HR in a year went nowhere after the operations director stepped in.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Someone stays while removing them would cost their protector more than keeping them.

WATCH FOR

Rules applied to others are waived for them.

ACT WITH

FT 2.06 Power/Interest Grid, to see who protects them. Unless you can move that person, you won't move this one.

WHAT EACH CHOICE COSTS THE DIRECTOR



2.04 The Quiet Exit

PROBLEM

Your best person checked out months before resigning

Nadia was the strongest analyst in credit control, and over the spring she went quiet. Her manager read it as a calm patch.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Many people decide to leave months before they resign, and their effort drops from then.

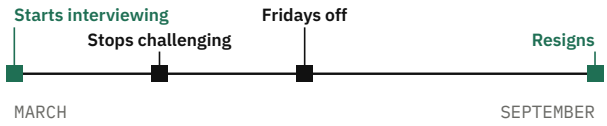
WATCH FOR

They stop asking about next year's plans or training.

ACT WITH

KP 7.07 One-to-ones, to hear plans and doubts while there is still time to talk about them.

NADIA'S SIX MONTHS



GREEN: THE DECISION AND THE EXIT. DARK: EVENTS.

2.05 The Safe Confidant

✓ SUCCESS

Everyone confides in one colleague, and nothing leaks

People across the office take their worries to Lucy in HR, and none of it has come back round. During a reorganisation, two directors asked her quietly how their teams would take it.

WHAT DRIVES IT

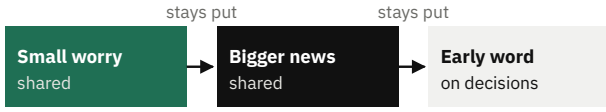
WHY

People tell things to the colleague who kept the last secret.

WATCH FOR

Colleagues from other teams seek you out to talk in private.

HOW THE CONFIDENCES GROW



2.06 The Loyalty Test

PROBLEM

You disagreed on the work, and it was taken as disloyalty

Rhys questioned his manager's supplier choice in a team review, with figures. Afterwards he was left off the steering group, and heard he had "gone against the team".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Under pressure, a team reads disagreement as a sign of whose side you are on.

WATCH FOR

Your objections are answered with who you work with.

THE SAME POINT, TWO READINGS

WHAT RHYS RAISED	WHAT WAS HEARD
Supplier costs 12% more	He opposes the manager
Figures from last year	He is not one of us

2.07 Role vs Rapport

PROBLEM

You stayed friends with your team, and couldn't act when it mattered

Owen was promoted to lead the sales team he had joined with Marta. When her numbers fell for two quarters, he kept saying it was a hard market, until his own boss asked why nothing had been done.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When the manager is also a friend, a hard decision feels like betrayal, so it gets put off.

WATCH FOR

You explain away one person's misses before anyone asks.

ACT WITH

FT 6.02 Radical Candor and SBI, to give honest feedback with care, on the record, as you would to anyone.

THE SAME MISS, TWO READINGS

AS HER FRIEND	AS HER MANAGER
A hard market	Two quarters short
Give her time	A plan is due

2.08 The Inside Track

PROBLEM

The boss's old colleague got the job, and nobody else had a real chance

A team lead role was advertised for two weeks. It went to Glen, who had worked with the director at his last company. Two internal candidates with better results were turned down.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People hire and protect those they already know, because it feels safe and saves judging a stranger.

WATCH FOR

New hires keep coming from the boss's old company.

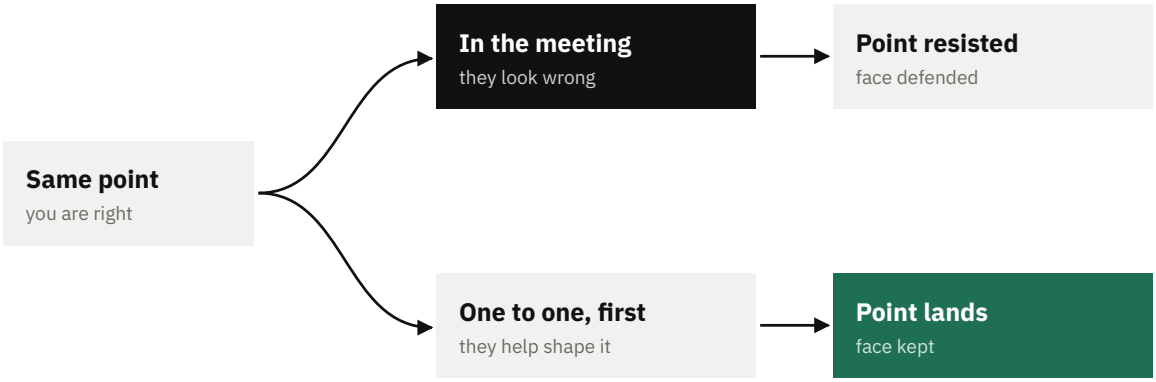
WHAT DECIDED IT

ON PAPER	IN PRACTICE
Better internal results	Worked with the director
An open advert	Hired in two weeks

03.

Face and Tact

Being right is rarely the problem. Making someone look wrong is.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Face**	3.01 The Lost Face · 3.05 Listen First ✓
2	**Reading intent**	3.02 The Defensive Apology · 3.04 The Cold Email · 3.06 The Clean Repair ✓
3	**Long memory**	3.01 The Lost Face · 3.03 The Flat No · 3.06 The Clean Repair ✓

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

You won an argument, and got fewer invitations after it.

Your emails get shorter replies with more people copied in.

You said no once, and the favours stopped.

3.01 The Lost Face

PROBLEM

You were right, and said it in a way that made them wrong

In the sales review, Omar showed that his manager's forecast counted two large orders twice. He was right, and the figure was fixed on the spot.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People corrected in front of others lose face, and they often make you pay for it later.

WATCH FOR

The room goes quiet after you win a point.

ACT WITH

FT 6.02 Radical Candor and SBI, to say the hard thing in a way the other person can take on board.

THE SAME CORRECTION, TWO SETTINGS

WITH AN AUDIENCE	WITH NO AUDIENCE
Wrong in front of peers	Wrong in private
Point won, face lost	Point won, face kept

3.02 The Defensive Apology

PROBLEM

Your apology made it worse

Ella in customer service sent a client's refund to the wrong account. She wrote that she was sorry, but the system had been slow.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Add a reason to an apology and the other person hears an excuse.

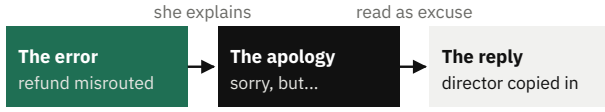
WATCH FOR

You reach for the reason before you name the harm.

ACT WITH

FT 6.04 Difficult Conversations, to separate what happened, how it felt and what it says about each of you.

HOW ELLA'S APOLOGY LANDED



3.03 The Flat No

PROBLEM

You said no and got called "not a team player"

Sara in sales asked Ben in accounts payable to rush a supplier payment before month end. Ben said no, as the cut-off had passed, and left it there.

WHAT DRIVES IT

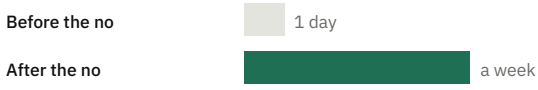
WHY

Teams run on favours, and a no with no reason sounds like you've stopped trading them.

WATCH FOR

Requests and favours from that person dry up.

TIME FOR BEN'S SALES DATA REQUESTS



3.04 The Cold Email

PROBLEM

Your email was read as rude

Hana, a new buying manager, emailed a supplier's account lead: "Need the revised prices by Friday. Thanks." The reply came a day late, ran to two lines, and copied in Hana's boss.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People read your email in the tone they already hear from you.

WATCH FOR

Replies to you open more formally than before.

ONE EMAIL, TWO READINGS

WHAT HANA MEANT	WHAT WAS READ
A clear deadline	An order from a newcomer
No time wasted	No greeting, no reason

3.05 Listen First

✓ SUCCESS

The new person who listened first got their changes through

Kofi joined as finance operations lead, planning to cut the month-end close from ten days to six. For six weeks he asked the team why each step existed.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A newcomer's plan sounds like criticism of the old way. A plan the team helped shape doesn't.

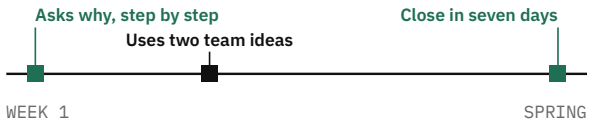
WATCH FOR

Old hands explain past attempts without being asked.

ACT WITH

FT 3.04 Design Thinking, to understand the people who do the work before proposing the change.

KOFI'S FIRST MONTHS



GREEN: THE TURN AND THE OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

3.06 The Clean Repair

✓ SUCCESS

A mistake was put right well, and trust went up

Rachel sent 3,000 clients a renewal letter with the wrong deadline. That morning she told her manager it was her error, said how, and had a correction out by noon.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People judge you by how you handle your own mistake, more than by the mistake.

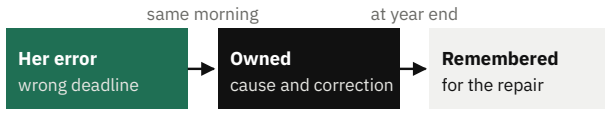
WATCH FOR

You are given work where errors are costly.

ACT WITH

KP 5.03 Shohō (first report), to make a first report on a problem, including one you caused yourself.

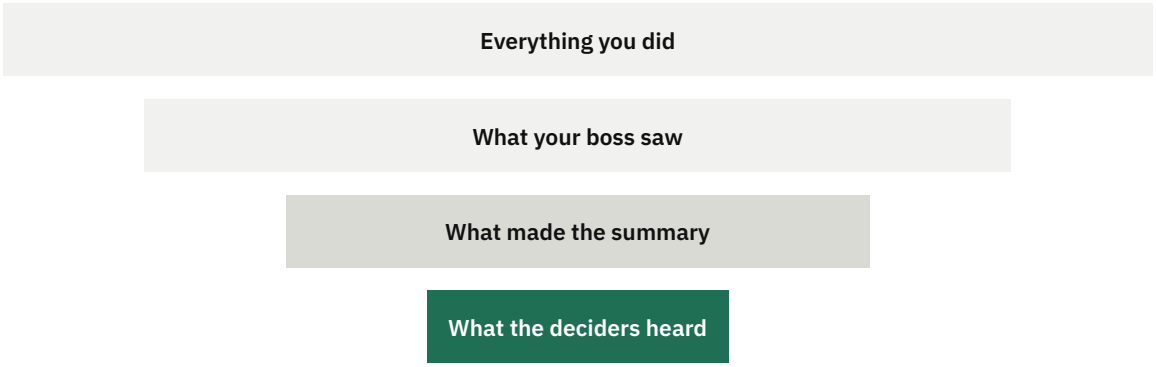
WHAT PEOPLE KEPT FROM RACHEL'S ERROR



04.

Getting Seen and Getting Credit

Bosses decide on the version of events that reaches them.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Who carries it**	4.01 The Last-Mile Gap · 4.02 Credit Capture · 4.05 The Go-To Person ✓ · 4.11 The Helpful Trap
2	**Memorable form**	4.03 The Hero Reward · 4.04 The Sticky Label · 4.06 The Number Speaks ✓ · 4.08 The Confidence Premium · 4.09 The Looks Premium · 4.12 The Last Month Counts
3	**Limited attention**	4.01 The Last-Mile Gap · 4.04 The Sticky Label · 4.06 The Number Speaks ✓ · 4.07 Borrowed Credibility · 4.09 The Looks Premium · 4.10 Out of Sight · 4.12 The Last Month Counts

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

Senior people describe your work in someone else's words.

The same fires keep coming back, and keep earning praise.

One word keeps coming up about you in reviews.

4.01 The Last-Mile Gap

PROBLEM

You do great work quietly, and nobody above you knows

Bea rebuilt the supplier payment checks, and late-payment penalties fell by a third. The finance director's list of the year's improvements left it out.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Deciders judge what reaches them, and work outside their plan seldom reaches them.

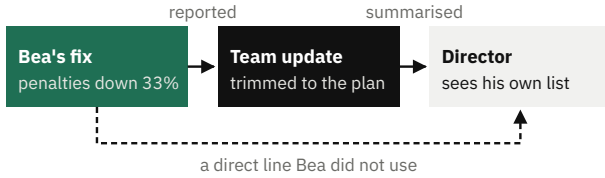
WATCH FOR

Others describe your work in their own words, or not at all.

ACT WITH

KP 3.01 Hōkoku (report early), to give your results a regular route to the people who decide.

HOW BEA'S RESULT WENT MISSING



4.02 Credit Capture

PROBLEM

Someone, sometimes your own boss, took credit for your team's work

Ravi's buying team renegotiated the freight contract, saving £260,000 a year. His manager, Claire, presented it to the executive committee while he was on leave.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

The person who presents the result to the boss gets the credit for it.

WATCH FOR

Slides about your work say "I" where you would say "we".

ACT WITH

KP 3.01 Hōkoku (report early), to get your result to the decider in your words first.

THE SAME SAVING, TWO VERSIONS

WHAT RAVI'S TEAM DID	WHAT THE CHAIR HEARD
Renegotiated the contract	Claire's freight deal
Saved £260,000 a year	Presented by Claire

4.03 The Hero Reward

PROBLEM

The firefighter gets praised, and the person who prevented the fire doesn't

Jo's night shift ran out of stock three times in a quarter, and each time Jo stayed late to ship. Ken's day shift re-planned its reorder points and had none.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A crisis gives people a story with a rescuer in it. A problem that was prevented leaves nothing to tell.

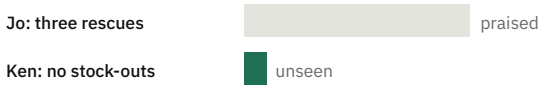
WATCH FOR

The same fires recur and keep earning praise.

ACT WITH

KP 5.02 Saihatsu bōshi (prevent recurrence), to turn a repeated rescue into a fix that stops the fire coming back.

WHAT THE AWARD PANEL NOTICED



4.04 The Sticky Label

PROBLEM

One bad moment gave you a label that stuck

In her first month as a regional sales manager, Freya lost her temper on a forecast call with the sales director. Two years on, her review still calls her "abrupt".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Busy bosses sum you up in one word, then notice what fits it.

WATCH FOR

Your feedback cites an old moment by name.

TWO YEARS, ONE WORD

WHAT HAPPENED	WHAT THE REVIEW SAYS
One outburst, month one	"Abrupt"
Best retention, two years	Left off the largest client

4.05 The Go-To Person

✓ SUCCESS

Someone rose fast without self-promotion

Megan in HR operations answered line managers' awkward contract questions the same day. When a head of HR services was needed, three directors named her before the job was advertised.

WHAT DRIVES IT

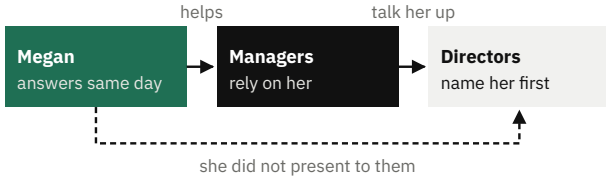
WHY

People who depend on you speak up for you in rooms you are not in.

WATCH FOR

People ask for you by name.

HOW MEGAN'S NAME TRAVELLED



4.06 The Number Speaks

✓ SUCCESS

Quiet work, even a support team's, got noticed once it carried a number

Yusuf's customer service team cut repeat calls for a year, unnoticed above their manager. Then he reported one figure: repeat calls down from 18 to 11 per cent.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A number survives every summary on the way up. The story gets cut.

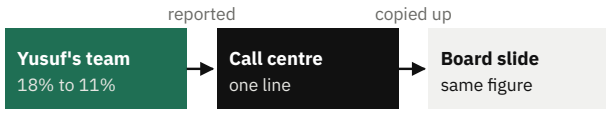
WATCH FOR

People quote your number before they know your name.

ACT WITH

KP 8.02 Baseline, to measure the before and after, so the change has a figure to travel with.

HOW THE FIGURE TRAVELLED



4.07 Borrowed Credibility

PROBLEM

A newcomer from a famous firm was believed before showing anything

Pedro joined the strategy team from a well-known consultancy. In his first month his proposals went through on one reading, while Elif, three years in, still had hers checked line by line.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When nobody can judge someone's ability, people go by the names on their CV.

WATCH FOR

Introductions lead with someone's last employer.

SAME KIND OF PROPOSAL, TWO RECEPTIONS

PEDRO'S PROPOSAL	ELIF'S PROPOSAL
Read once	Checked line by line
Approved in the meeting	Sent back for more detail

4.08 The Confidence Premium

PROBLEM

The confident speaker won the argument with weaker evidence

At the pricing review, Oscar spoke without notes and gave one firm number. Tara had the fuller analysis but opened with its limits, and the board went with Oscar's figure.

WHAT DRIVES IT

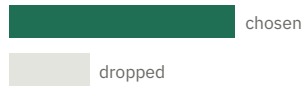
WHY

People take a confident speaker for a competent one, because checking the evidence takes time.

WATCH FOR

Careful answers get more questions than bold ones.

HOW EACH CASE LANDED



4.09 The Looks Premium

PROBLEM

A colleague who looks the part got the work you were better at

Bruno and Stefan had matching sales figures. Bruno is tall, sharply dressed and easy in front of clients, and was given the biggest account. Stefan was told he needed more “presence”.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People decide in seconds whether someone looks capable, and that first view colours how they judge the work.

WATCH FOR

Your feedback mentions presence, with no examples.

SAME NUMBERS, DIFFERENT PICK

STEFAN	BRUNO
Sales: 112% of target	Sales: 112% of target
Told to build presence	Given the biggest account

4.10 Out of Sight

PROBLEM

You work from home and keep missing out on the good projects

Hamid works from home three days a week and hits every deadline. The new client project went to Pete, who sits by the manager and stays late most evenings.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Bosses give the good work to whoever they see, and staying late at a desk reads as commitment.

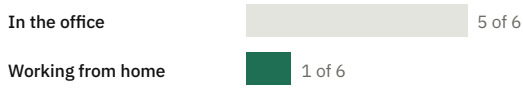
WATCH FOR

You hear about new work after it has been handed out.

ACT WITH

KP 3.01 Hōkoku (report early), to send a short weekly update, so your work reaches the boss even when you don't.

WHO GOT THE NEW PROJECTS THIS YEAR



4.11 The Helpful Trap

PROBLEM

You do all the extra jobs nobody else wants, and it never counts

Lorna takes the meeting notes, onboards every new starter and organises the team events. At her review she was thanked warmly and rated the same as last year.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Work that keeps a team running gets thanks. Promotions go to the work leaders see and measure.

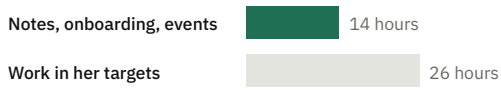
WATCH FOR

People bring you the admin first, out of habit.

ACT WITH

KP 2.11 Task rotation, to rotate the thankless jobs, so they stop landing on one person.

WHERE LORNA'S WEEK WENT



4.12 The Last Month Counts

PROBLEM

A strong year was forgotten because of one weak month before the review

Niall closed the year's two biggest deals in March and June. In November a launch he ran slipped by a week. His review called the year “mixed”.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Reviews are written from what the boss remembers, and they remember the last few weeks best.

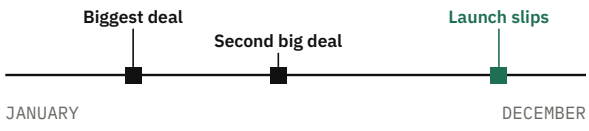
WATCH FOR

Your boss can't name your early wins without a prompt.

ACT WITH

KP 8.02 Baseline, to keep a dated record of your results through the year, ready for the review.

NIALL'S YEAR, AS THE REVIEW SAW IT

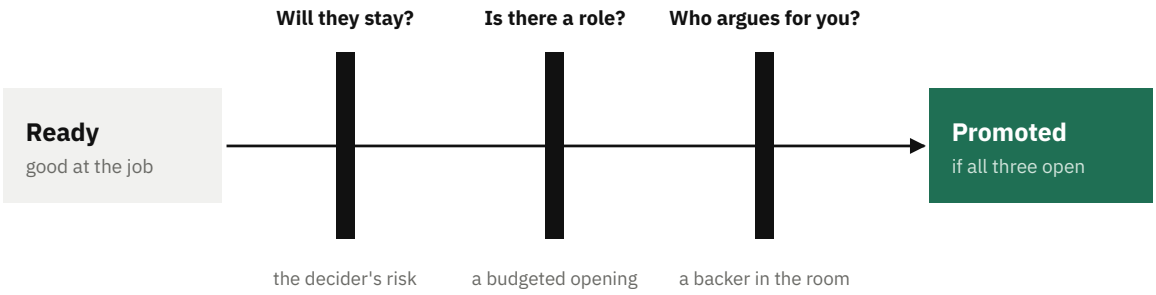


GREEN: WHAT THE REVIEW REMEMBERED. DARK: EVENTS.

05.

Who Gets Promoted

Eleven reasons a deserving person stalls, and one way a role becomes yours.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1 The decider's risk

5.01 The Rising Star Penalty · 5.02 The Indispensability Trap · 5.05 The External Reset · 5.06 The Acting Role That Stuck ✓ · 5.10 The Age Filter · 5.11 The Carer Penalty

2 Next-role proof

5.03 The Next-Level Test · 5.06 The Acting Role That Stuck ✓ · 5.07 The Potential Label · 5.08 Set Up to Fail

3 Who backs you

5.04 Mentor, No Sponsor · 5.05 The External Reset · 5.09 The Culture Fit · 5.12 The Head Office Advantage

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

Your results are the best, and the step up went to someone else.

Your manager says they could not cope without you.

Nobody senior has talked to you about your next two years.

5.01 The Rising Star Penalty

PROBLEM

The top performer was passed over: seen as a flight risk

Simone was the top salesperson in her region three years running, and a rival made her an offer last spring. The regional manager role went to Paul, who had ten steady years.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A promotion is an investment, and bosses invest in people they expect to stay.

WATCH FOR

You win awards, but nobody asks about your next two years.

FLIGHT RISK AS A DECIDER SEES IT



5.02 The Indispensability Trap

PROBLEM

You're too good in your job to be moved up

Dina is the one person in finance who understands the month-end reconciliations. When a senior post came up, her manager told the panel she was "not ready to move yet".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Your manager pays the cost of moving you up, so it suits them to keep you where you are.

WATCH FOR

Your leave is hard to approve because nobody can cover.

ACT WITH

KP 2.05 Backup cover, to build cover for your work, so moving you up no longer leaves a gap.

THE COST AS A MANAGER SEES IT

IF DINA MOVES UP	IF DINA STAYS
Find and train a replacement	Close runs smoothly
Close at risk for months	Manager's numbers likely safe

5.03 The Next-Level Test

PROBLEM

Your results were the best, and someone else was promoted

Callum had the highest output in the claims team for two years. The team leader post went to Grace, who already trained new starters.

WHAT DRIVES IT

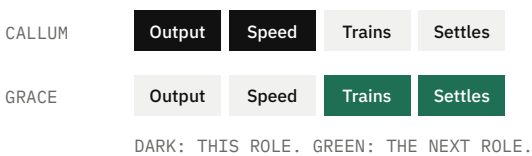
WHY

The step up is judged on the skills of the next job, such as leading other people.

WATCH FOR

"Presence" in feedback can mean looks (4.09) or fit (5.09).

WHAT EACH HAD SHOWN



5.04 Mentor, No Sponsor

PROBLEM

You had a mentor, but nobody argued for you

Aisha met her mentor, a marketing director, every month for a year. At the promotion round her manager spoke for someone else, and her name was set aside.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Managers argue promotions out in a room, and your name needs someone senior to speak for it.

WATCH FOR

Nobody senior could make your case without you there.

ADVICE VERSUS A VOICE IN THE ROOM

WHAT HER MENTOR GAVE	WHAT THE ROUND NEEDED
Advice every month	A voice for her name
Absent from the round	Someone senior in the room

5.05 The External Reset

PROBLEM

The outsider got the job you were sure was yours

When the head of purchasing retired, Ines and Victor, two category managers with loyal teams, each expected the job. After four months the director hired Carol from a competitor.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Picking one of two rival insiders upsets the other's camp. Hiring from outside avoids the choice.

WATCH FOR

Talk turns to "fresh eyes" or "outside experience".

TWO CHOICES, TWO COSTS

PROMOTE INES OR VICTOR	HIRE FROM OUTSIDE
One camp feels beaten	Neither camp loses
Risk of exits	No ranking to explain

5.06 The Acting Role That Stuck

✓ SUCCESS

An acting role became permanent

When the customer service manager left suddenly, Tariq was made acting manager while HR ran a search. Four months later the search closed and his title lost "acting".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Once you are doing the job well, every other choice looks riskier to the person deciding.

WATCH FOR

The search for a permanent hire slows or goes quiet.

TARIQ'S FOUR MONTHS



GREEN: THE TURN AND OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

5.07 The Potential Label

PROBLEM

They had less to show, but were seen as having more potential

Jamal and Petra had similar results, but Jamal was marked high potential after one strong talk to the leadership team. He got the development programme, and Petra got a note to raise her profile.

WHAT DRIVES IT

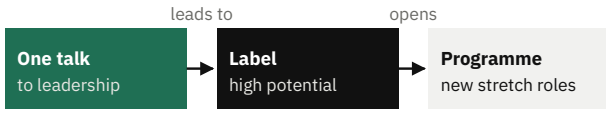
WHY

Potential is a guess, and the guess rests on a few moments the deciders saw.

WATCH FOR

Talent reviews discuss your style more than your results.

HOW ONE MOMENT BECOMES A CAREER PATH



5.08 Set Up to Fail

PROBLEM

You got the bigger role without what it needed, then were judged unready

Bridget was asked to run the struggling Midlands branch for six months, alongside her own job and under a hiring freeze. When results stayed flat, her review said "not yet ready".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Give someone a bigger job with no time, people or authority, and they get blamed if it fails.

WATCH FOR

The step-up comes with no change to your current workload.

ACT WITH

FT 4.05 Triple Constraint, to agree scope, time and resources before you take the role.

THE ROLE AND ITS CONDITIONS

WHAT SHE WAS GIVEN	WHAT SHE LACKED
A struggling branch	Time off her own job
Six months to turn it	Staff, under a freeze
	Authority to hire

5.09 The Culture Fit

PROBLEM

You were turned down as “not a fit”, and nobody could say why

Maya reached the final round for a senior role. The whole panel had been to the same two universities and played in the same golf society. The feedback said she was “not quite a fit”.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People hire and promote those who remind them of themselves, and call it fit.

WATCH FOR

Feedback says fit, style or chemistry, with no examples.

WHAT THE PANEL SHARED

THE PANEL	MAYA
Same two universities	A different university
Same golf society	Results in the top fifth

5.10 The Age Filter

PROBLEM

You were passed over because of your age, though nobody said so

Clive, 58, applied to lead the new online sales team. It went to someone fifteen years younger with less experience. The feedback praised Clive's “depth” and said the role needed “fresh energy”.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Age gets judged without being named. Older people are seen as slow or costly, younger people as untested.

WATCH FOR

You're called experienced and steady, never a future leader.

THE WORDS, AND WHAT THEY MEANT

WHAT WAS SAID	WHAT IT MEANT
Valuable depth	Too senior to retrain
Needs fresh energy	Too old for the role

5.11 The Carer Penalty

PROBLEM

Since you started caring for someone, the big work goes elsewhere

Vikram started caring for his father after a stroke, and now leaves at five. His biggest client went to a colleague “to take the pressure off”. Nobody asked him.

WHAT DRIVES IT

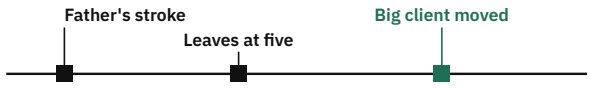
WHY

Once someone has caring duties, bosses decide for them that they want less, and the big work moves away.

WATCH FOR

Work is moved “to take the pressure off” without asking you.

VIKRAM'S YEAR



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

5.12 The Head Office Advantage

PROBLEM

Your regional team does the work, and head office gets the promotions

Sofia's team in the Manila office runs the whole billing process. When a global lead role opened, it went to someone in London who had managed the team for six months.

WHAT DRIVES IT

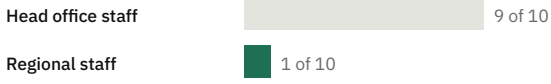
WHY

Promotions go to people the senior leaders see, in their own office, time zone and language.

WATCH FOR

Senior visits to your office are rare and short.

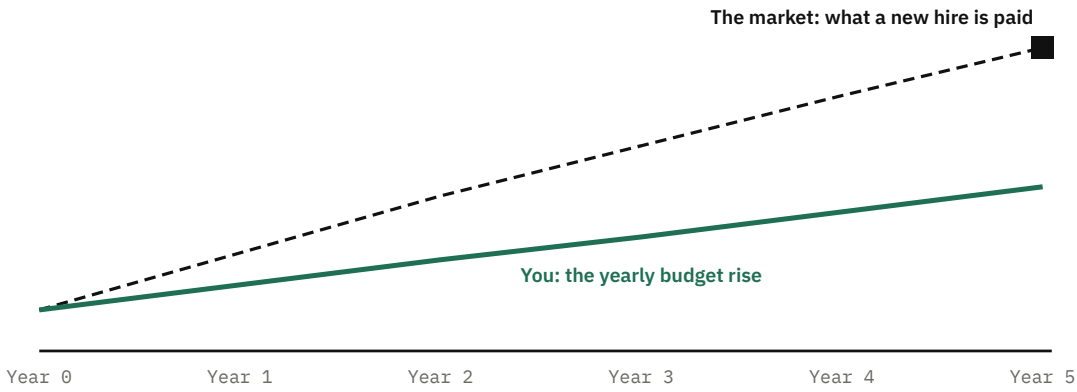
GLOBAL ROLES FILLED THIS YEAR



06.

What You're Worth

Pay, openings and investment follow budgets and bargaining power more than effort.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1 Bargaining power

- 6.01 The Market Price
- 6.02 The Retention Paradox
- 6.06 Replacement Cost ✓
- 6.10 The Captive Discount

2 Budgets set first

- 6.03 The Fixed Pool
- 6.04 The Vacancy Lottery
- 6.05 The Cost-Centre Penalty
- 6.09 The Target Ratchet
- 6.11 The Contractor Line

3 Senior visibility

- 6.05 The Cost-Centre Penalty
- 6.06 Replacement Cost ✓
- 6.07 The Protected Team ✓
- 6.08 The Success Tax

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

A new hire in your role earns more than you do.

You were told you are ready, and nothing opened up.

Your team is early in freezes and late in hiring.

6.01 The Market Price

PROBLEM

Two equally skilled people started on very different salaries

Zoe and Mark joined accounts payable a month apart with the same qualifications. Zoe had a second offer, and her post had sat empty for three months.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Starting pay depends on each side's bargaining power on the day you are hired, more than on skill.

WATCH FOR

Colleagues hired in a rush earn more for the same work.

STARTING PAY, SAME SKILLS



6.02 The Retention Paradox

PROBLEM

The new hire earns more than you, and resigning got you a rise

Keith ran the payroll desk for five years. When he resigned for a job elsewhere, his manager matched the outside offer within a week.

WHAT DRIVES IT

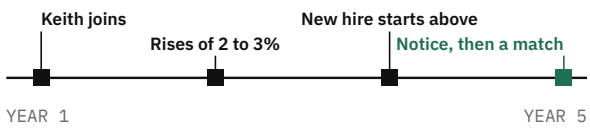
WHY

Your pay is set to the market when you join, then grows by the yearly budget percentage.

WATCH FOR

Counteroffers appear after resignations.

KEITH'S FIVE YEARS



GREEN: THE TURN. DARK: EVENTS.

6.03 The Fixed Pool

PROBLEM

Your great year got almost the same rise as everyone else

Mei ended the year with the best collection rate in credit control. Her review said exceptional, and her rise was four per cent.

WHAT DRIVES IT

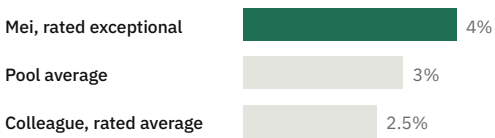
WHY

When the rise budget is fixed before reviews, the best person gets little more than the average.

WATCH FOR

The rise budget is announced before reviews are done.

RISES FROM A 3% POOL



6.04 The Vacancy Lottery

PROBLEM

You met the bar, and there was no promotion to give

Leila was told at her review that she was ready to be a buying manager. None of the three buying managers planned to leave, and she waited a year.

WHAT DRIVES IT

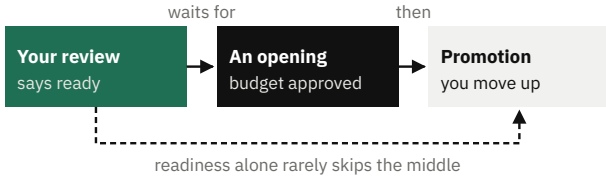
WHY

A promotion needs an approved, budgeted opening, and being ready does not create one.

WATCH FOR

You are called ready in two reviews running, with no date.

HOW A PROMOTION OPENS



6.05 The Cost-Centre Penalty

PROBLEM

Work that doesn't bring in money gets the least, even when the team is drowning

Rosa's accounts receivable team worked overtime most weeks of a busy year. In the autumn freeze it lost its one open post.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Budgets follow the money coming in, so the teams that support it are the first to be cut.

WATCH FOR

Roles in your area are tied to a project end date.

POSTS ADDED OR LOST THIS YEAR

REVENUE TEAMS	ROSA'S TEAM
+4 posts	3 posts lost
Tied to sales growth	1 open post cut in the freeze
	2 seconded staff let go

6.06 Replacement Cost

✓ SUCCESS

Someone got a big rise without threatening to leave

Before reviews, Felix's boss in customer service costed what losing him would mean and put the figure in her pay request. He had not mentioned leaving.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A rise gets approved when the boss can see what losing you would cost.

WATCH FOR

Your boss asks about your plans before review season.

THE SAME PAY REQUEST, TWO WAYS

WITHOUT A FIGURE	WITH ONE
"Felix does great work"	Six months to replace him
Rise from the usual band	Three key accounts at risk
	Eleven per cent approved

6.07 The Protected Team

✓ SUCCESS

A team was spared when budgets were cut

When the company cut ten per cent of overhead, the complaints team kept every post. The chief executive had praised its results twice at staff briefings.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Cuts land on the teams with nobody senior to speak for them.

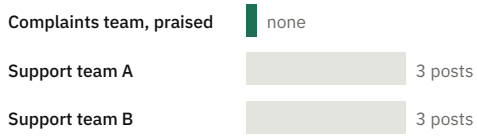
WATCH FOR

Leaders mention the team's work unprompted in updates.

ACT WITH

FT 2.06 Power/Interest Grid, to see who holds power over your team's budget, and who speaks for it.

POSTS LOST IN THE 10% CUT



6.08 The Success Tax

PROBLEM

You're the reliable one, so you get everyone else's work

Wendy in accounts never misses a close, so two extra reconciliations and the audit requests landed on her desk this year. Her title, grade and pay stayed the same.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Extra work goes to the person least likely to drop it, and soon it counts as their normal job.

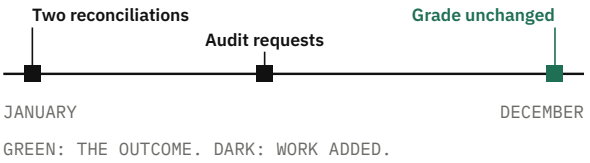
WATCH FOR

New tasks reach you with "you're the only one who can".

ACT WITH

KP 2.03 Intake rule, to make new work visible and agreed before it lands on one person.

WENDY'S YEAR



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: WORK ADDED.

6.09 The Target Ratchet

PROBLEM

You beat your target, so next year's went up

Leon's region beat its sales target by twenty per cent, and his next target rose by twenty-five. A colleague who just made his number got a small increase.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Beat this year's target and next year's goes up, so people learn to hold back.

WATCH FOR

Colleagues time deals to fall into the next quarter.

NEXT YEAR'S TARGET INCREASE



6.10 The Captive Discount

PROBLEM

You can't easily leave, and your pay shows it

Anton's work visa ties him to his employer, and changing jobs would mean a new application. His rises have trailed the team's for three years. His manager knows why he stays.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Pay follows how easily you could leave, so the people who can't leave get less.

WATCH FOR

Your rises trail those of colleagues who could leave.

ANTON'S RISES AGAINST THE TEAM'S



6.11 The Contractor Line

PROBLEM

As a contractor you do the work, and the staff get the credit

Joanna, a contractor, rebuilt the month-end reporting in six weeks. The permanent team lead presented it. When the budget was cut, her contract was the first to go.

WHAT DRIVES IT

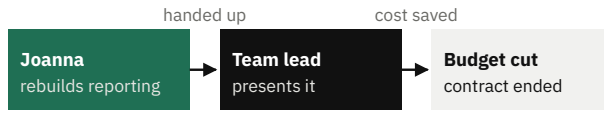
WHY

Contractors sit outside the team that gets credit and protection, so they are the first cost to cut.

WATCH FOR

Your work is presented by someone on the staff.

HOW JOANNA'S WORK TRAVELLED



07.

Where Decisions Are Made

The real decision usually happens before, after or outside the meeting.

HOW MUCH OF THE OUTCOME IS SHAPED HERE



Before
talks, pre-meetings

The meeting
announced, confirmed

After
quiet resistance, delay

WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Talks off agenda**	7.01 The Pre-Meeting ± · 7.03 Meeting Theatre · 7.06 The Orphan Owner ✓ · 7.09 The After-Hours Circle
2	**Face and cover**	7.02 The Outsider's Voice · 7.03 Meeting Theatre · 7.05 The Sponsor's Project · 7.07 The Default Decision · 7.08 Responsibility Without Authority
3	**Partial views**	7.04 The Metric Trap · 7.06 The Orphan Owner ✓

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

Decisions are settled before the meeting you prepared for.

An idea you raised is approved once an adviser raises it.

Your team hits its target while complaints rise.

7.01 The Pre-Meeting

± WORKS BOTH WAYS

You didn't see the decision coming, or your idea got a yes before the meeting started

Before the purchasing review, Carla met the finance director and two plant managers one to one about a new packaging supplier. Dan brought a rival plan to the meeting itself.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Most decisions are made in short talks beforehand, and the meeting confirms them.

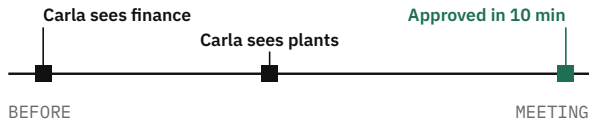
WATCH FOR

Key people met the decision-maker in the days before.

ACT WITH

KP 3.05 Nemawashi, to build support before the meeting, openly.

CARLA'S ROUTE TO A YES



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

7.02 The Outsider's Voice

PROBLEM

The consultant said what you said a year ago, and now it's approved

Last spring Imran proposed merging the two customer service queues, and his paper was "noted". This spring an outside firm recommended the same merger.

WHAT DRIVES IT

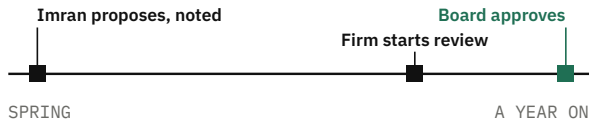
WHY

An outside adviser's word carries weight, and the adviser takes the blame if it fails.

WATCH FOR

Your proposal is "noted", and a review is commissioned.

SAME IDEA, TWO VOICES



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

7.03 Meeting Theatre

PROBLEM

Everyone agreed in the meeting, then resisted afterwards

At the operations meeting, the new shift pattern was agreed with no questions. Three weeks later two of four depot managers had not rostered it, citing a union consultation nobody had mentioned.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

People who won't object in the meeting object later by being slow to act.

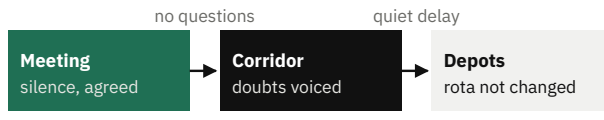
WATCH FOR

Objections come up in corridors after the meeting.

ACT WITH

KP 3.04 Gijiroku (meeting record), to write down who agreed to what, so delay shows early.

WHERE THE OBJECTION GOES



7.04 The Metric Trap

PROBLEM

The team hit the number and hurt the business

The call centre was set a target of four minutes per call. Within one quarter, two of its largest customers had written to complain.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Once a number becomes the target, people work to the number and lose sight of why it was set.

WATCH FOR

Work is closed or passed on just before the measuring point.

ONE QUARTER ON THE TARGET

WHAT THE TARGET SAW	WHAT CUSTOMERS GOT
Handling time down a third	Repeat calls doubled
Most calls under four minutes	Closed but not fixed

7.05 The Sponsor's Project

PROBLEM

The project everyone knows is dead is still funded

Moving all suppliers onto one national contract was the operations director's plan. Eighteen months in, savings stood at a fifth of target.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A failing project keeps its funding while the senior who backs it is still in the job.

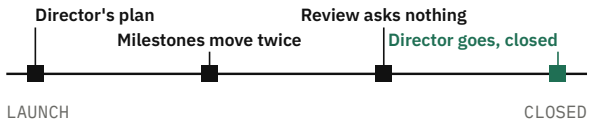
WATCH FOR

The project's targets are quietly restated.

ACT WITH

FT 2.06 Power/Interest Grid, to find who could give it an exit. The sponsor won't kill their own project.

ONE PROGRAMME, LAUNCH TO CLOSE



GREEN: THE TURN. DARK: EVENTS.

7.06 The Orphan Owner

✓ SUCCESS

The person who took on the problem nobody owned got promoted

Late supplier invoices bounced between buying, finance and the warehouse for a year. Olga, in accounts payable, offered to own the problem.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Whoever takes on a problem between teams ends up seeing it whole, and nobody else does.

WATCH FOR

A problem everyone mentions has no team that owns it.

ACT WITH

KP 2.01 One owner, to put one name on each problem.

LATE INVOICES, BEFORE AND AFTER

NOBODY OWNS IT	OLGA OWNS IT
Buying points to finance	One name to call
Finance points to warehouse	One view across teams
Director asks around	Teams send disputes to her

7.07 The Default Decision

PROBLEM

Nobody said no, and nothing changed

The proposal to merge two regional warehouses went to the operations board three times. Each time it was sent back for more analysis, and a year later both sites were still running.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When saying yes means owning the risk, people ask for more analysis, and nothing changes.

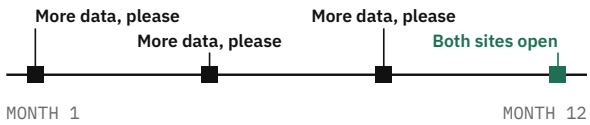
WATCH FOR

The same item returns to the agenda with no owner or date.

ACT WITH

KP 2.02 Decision levels, to name who decides what, and by when, so a choice cannot drift.

THE WAREHOUSE PROPOSAL



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: BOARD REVIEWS.

7.08 Responsibility Without Authority

PROBLEM

You're accountable for the result, but others control what it needs

Harriet was made responsible for cutting customer complaints by a third. The call centre, the returns team and the budget all sat under other managers.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

It is easy to make someone accountable. The budget and people they need stay with other managers.

WATCH FOR

Your target depends on people who do not report to you.

ACT WITH

FT 5.02 RACI Matrix, to get on record who decides. A chart won't give you authority, but it shows who has it.

WHO HOLDS WHAT

HARRIET HOLDS	OTHERS HOLD
The complaints target	The call centre team
The monthly report	The returns team
	The budget

7.09 The After-Hours Circle

PROBLEM

The real decisions get made at drinks you don't go to

Every Thursday the sales leads go to the pub with their director. Ruth collects her children at six. By Monday the new territories are agreed, and hers is the smallest.

WHAT DRIVES IT

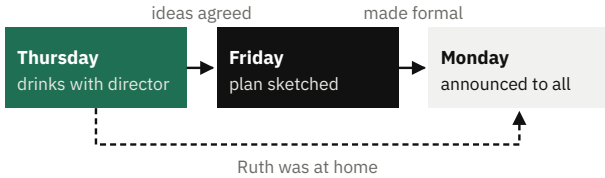
WHY

Decisions get shaped where people relax together, and those who don't join hear about them afterwards.

WATCH FOR

Meetings confirm things you never heard discussed.

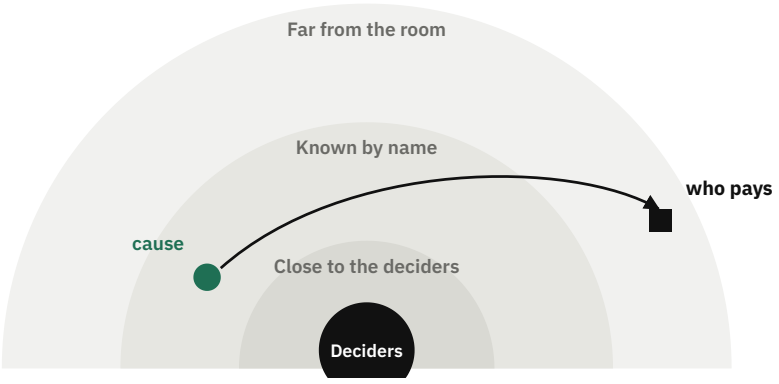
HOW THE TERRITORIES WERE SET



08.

When Things Go Wrong

After a failure or a cut, who pays depends on power and evidence as much as on cause.



WHAT DRIVES THIS PART

1	**Nearness to power**	8.01 The Scapegoat Mechanism · 8.02 The Bad News Penalty · 8.05 The Cut List · 8.07 Someone Else Pays · 8.08 The Inherited Result · 8.10 The Expensive Target
2	**Safety to speak**	8.02 The Bad News Penalty · 8.03 Watermelon Status · 8.06 Owned Out Loud ✓ · 8.11 The Health Shadow
3	**Senior face**	8.02 The Bad News Penalty · 8.04 The Date From Above · 8.06 Owned Out Loud ✓ · 8.09 The Rescue Expectation

SIGNS THIS PART IS ABOUT YOU

- You acted on a risky call agreed in a corridor and never written down.
- Your project reports green and you are not sure it is.
- A reorganisation is rumoured, and the deciders barely know your work.

8.01 The Scapegoat Mechanism

PROBLEM

Something big went wrong, and you became the scapegoat

A supplier contract renewed at the old price cost the company £400,000. Chen, the buyer, had flagged the price, and his director told him in a corridor to sign anyway.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

After a failure, people want one name fast, and the written record decides whose.

WATCH FOR

Requests to confirm a go-ahead in writing go unanswered.

ACT WITH

KP 3.04 Gijiroku (meeting record), to put decisions, and who approved them, on record when they are made.

WHAT THE REVIEW COULD SEE

ON FILE	NOT ON FILE
Chen's signature	The director's go-ahead
The renewed contract	Chen's spoken warning

8.02 The Bad News Penalty

PROBLEM

The person who raised the alarm got the blame

In March Noor warned the sales director that a large customer was likely to move to a rival. He had told the board the account was secure, and her warning was called "alarmist".

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When the news embarrasses someone senior, the person who brought it gets the blame.

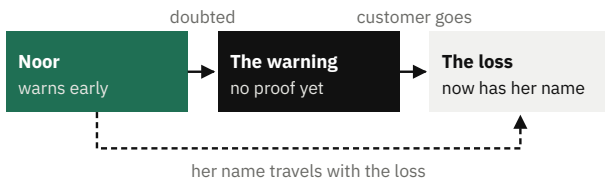
WATCH FOR

You are asked for your source more than for the facts.

ACT WITH

KP 5.03 Shohō (first report), to report early, in writing. You may still take the heat, but the record shows you warned.

HOW THE MESSENGER GETS LINKED



8.03 Watermelon Status

PROBLEM

Every project is green until the week it goes red

Gareth's office move reported green for five months while the fit-out contractor slipped. It went red three weeks before the old lease ended.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

Owners keep a project green, because reporting a problem costs more than hoping.

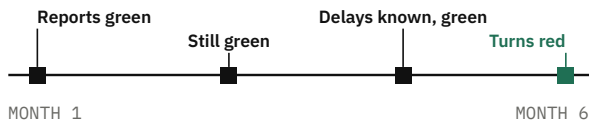
WATCH FOR

The colour holds while dates in the detail move.

ACT WITH

KP 7.01 Mieruka (team board), to show work and blockers as they are, where the whole team can see them.

GARETH'S MONTHLY REPORTS



GREEN: THE TURN. DARK: MONTHLY REPORTS.

8.04 The Date From Above

PROBLEM

The deadline was set before anyone asked how long it would take

The finance director told the board the monthly close would take five days instead of ten by June. Nina's team heard the date at kick-off, before anyone had mapped the steps.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When a date is promised before anyone scopes the work, the plan gets bent to fit the date.

WATCH FOR

A date is announced before the scope is written.

ACT WITH

FT 4.05 Triple Constraint, to show in writing what the date costs. The date rarely moves. The scope has to.

TWO WAYS TO BUILD A PLAN

FROM THE WORK	FROM THE DATE
Steps mapped first	Date promised to the board
Estimate, then a date	Steps cut to fit

8.05 The Cut List

PROBLEM

A reorganisation cut your role and kept a weaker colleague

When two regional sales offices merged, Hugo's manager had two days to name four roles to cut. Hugo had the best numbers but worked from a satellite office and rarely met the regional director.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

When a cut list is drawn up in a hurry, the people the deciders know get kept.

WATCH FOR

Meeting invitations change before anything is announced.

EASE OF DEFENDING A NAME UPWARD



8.06 Owned Out Loud

✓ SUCCESS

A big failure, and nobody was hung out to dry

A missed delivery left the largest retail customer with empty shelves for a week. On the all-staff call, the logistics director said she had approved the shortcut behind it and named nobody else.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

How the boss responds to a failure in public shows the whole team what is safe to admit.

WATCH FOR

People describe their own part in a failure unprompted.

ACT WITH

KP 8.07 Hansei, to make owning a failure a team habit through regular reflection.

SMALL PROBLEMS FLAGGED BEFORE CUSTOMERS



8.07 Someone Else Pays

PROBLEM

Sales promised it, and another team paid for the promise

To win a large retail contract, Abdul in sales agreed next-day delivery to every store. He earned his bonus that quarter, and the warehouse ran overtime for the next two years.

WHAT DRIVES IT

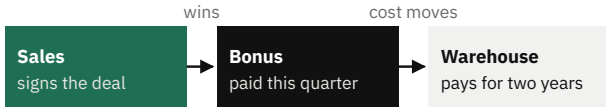
WHY

The person who makes the promise is rewarded on the day, and someone else pays for it later.

WATCH FOR

Promises are made in meetings delivery never attends.

WHERE THE WIN AND THE COST LAND



8.08 The Inherited Result

PROBLEM

You took over a failing project, and its record became yours

Arjun took over a delayed office relocation in month eight. By month eleven, the steering slides showed the delay under his name, with no mention of when it began.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

A result belongs to whoever owns it now, and people forget fast when the problem started.

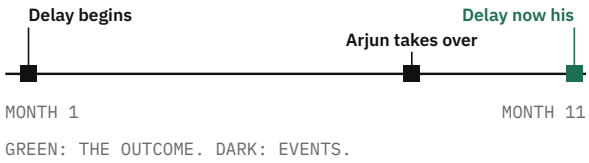
WATCH FOR

Old delays appear in your reports without their start dates.

ACT WITH

KP 8.02 Baseline, to record where things stood on the day you took over, with dates.

ARJUN'S PROJECT, AS THE SLIDES TOLD IT



GREEN: THE OUTCOME. DARK: EVENTS.

8.09 The Rescue Expectation

PROBLEM

You were brought in to fix it, and given no time to find out what was wrong

Beth was hired to turn round a struggling customer service team. In her second week, her director asked for “the recovery numbers” at the monthly review.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

The person brought in to fix something is judged on speed before anyone knows the cause.

WATCH FOR

You are asked for results before anyone asks what you found.

EXPECTED, AND NEEDED

EXPECTED BY WEEK 2	NEEDED FIRST
Recovery numbers	Why the team struggles
A turnaround date	What customers report

8.10 The Expensive Target

PROBLEM

When cuts came, the best-paid people went first

Facing a 10% cost target, the director removed the three highest salaries in the department. Two of them were the strongest performers. Their work was split among cheaper staff.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

In a cut, salary is the easiest number to see, so the best-paid people go first.

WATCH FOR

Talk of cost turns to headcount and grades.

WHAT THE CUT WAS BASED ON

KEPT	CUT
Cheaper roles	Three top salaries
Less experience	Two strongest performers

8.11 The Health Shadow

PROBLEM

After your illness, the important work quietly stopped coming

Martin was off for four months after surgery. Since he came back he has done his job well, but new projects keep going to others “so as not to overload him”.

WHAT DRIVES IT

WHY

After a long illness, bosses see a risk in relying on you, and send the important work elsewhere.

WATCH FOR

New work is handed out “to spare you”, without asking.

BEFORE AND AFTER THE SURGERY

BEFORE	AFTER
Led two new projects	Routine work
Lead on a key client	Projects go to others

S.

Scenarios

45 situations where several patterns hit at once, and what to do about them.

HOW EACH SCENARIO READS

1
The situation
What you walk into, and the two ways to get it wrong.

2
If you do nothing
A diagram of who and what works against you, with the pattern behind each.

3
What to do
Steps in order, grouped into phases.

4
The black band
How these situations usually end.

THE DIAGRAMS

Pressure map	many parties press on you at once
Caught between	two sides pull you different ways
Timeline	how it unfolds if you do nothing
Fork	too hard, too soft, and what works
Chain	how blame or news travels, and where it lands
Before and after	how relationships change
Bottleneck	everything runs through one point
Bars	the numbers that do not add up

Before you start: HR protects the company. It is not there to protect you.

Use HR for policy and paperwork. Keep your own dated record, and get outside advice when your job or your rights are at stake.

THE THREE GROUPS

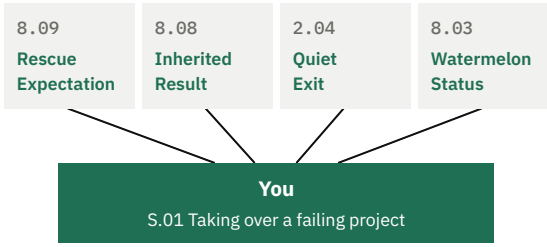
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The full list 44

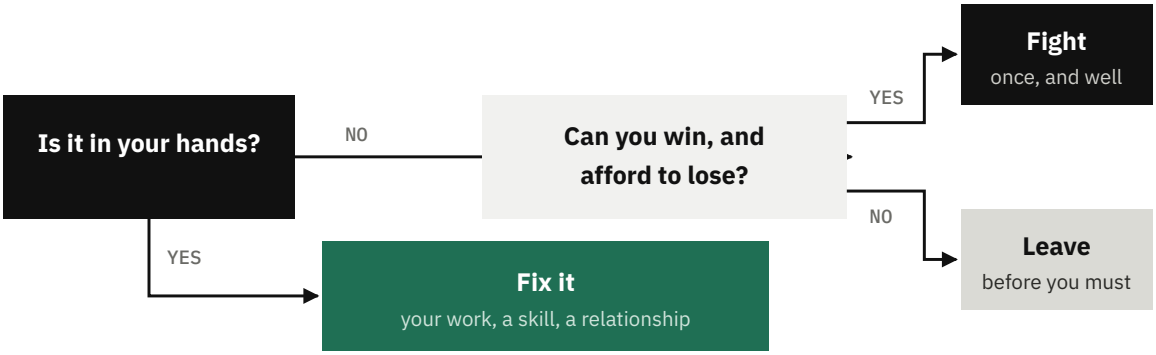
HOW PATTERNS MEET



Before the scenarios

Fix it, fight, or leave

Every scenario comes down to one of three moves. Each scenario page says which one it usually is.



Fix it

when the problem is in your own hands.

Your work, a skill, how you handle people, or a relationship that can be repaired.

Nobody senior has decided against you.

Fixing it costs you time, and leaves your standing intact.

Fight

only when all three are true.

Someone senior will back you, or the issue costs the company money it can see.

You'd still be all right if you lost.

It's worth more than the goodwill you'll spend.

Leave

when any of these is true.

The decision has been made above you, and your boss won't or can't change it.

Your backer has gone, and the new boss has their own people.

You've raised it properly and nothing has changed in six months.

Your pay is well below market, and they'll only match it if you resign.

It's costing your health.

Most fights fail one of the three tests. Then fix what you can, or leave.

Start looking before you have to. You choose better when you are not desperate.

Scenarios

45 situations, three groups

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S.01

USUALLY: FIX

Taking over a failing project

You take over a project halfway through. The client has rated it poorly, the team is demoralised, and your predecessor promised a date that looks impossible.

Blame the previous team and you lose their cooperation. Defend them and their failure becomes yours.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

Your boss
expects quick results, not a long diagnosis
8.09 **The Rescue Expectation**

The old results
start to count against you after a few weeks
8.08 **The Inherited Result**

The client
stays unhappy while status reports show green
8.03 **Watermelon Status**

Your team
weak performers stay, strong ones start to leave
2.04 **The Quiet Exit**

You
if it fails, you are the easiest person to blame
8.01 **The Scapegoat Mechanism**

HR
cannot support a decision with nothing in writing

WHAT TO DO

DAYS 1 TO 30
Understand

1. Meet each team member one to one: what works, what blocks them, what they need.
2. Meet the client and anyone who judges the work. Ask what “fixed” means to them.
3. Send your boss a written assessment and a 90-day plan with dates, including whether the promised date can still be met. Keep a copy as your record.

DAYS 31 TO 60
Set expectations

4. Agree written goals with each person.
5. Where someone falls short after clear feedback, start a performance improvement plan (PIP) with HR. By then the decision is usually made. The PIP is the formal route out.
6. Still coach them properly. Some do turn it round.
7. Track progress weekly, and line up a replacement in case.

DAYS 61 TO 90
Decide and hand over

8. Recognise those who improved, in front of the team.
9. For those who didn't, talk privately before the formal step. Where policy allows, offer a mutual exit: they resign, with an agreed reference and leaving date.
10. If they want help finding a new job, give it: introductions, time off for interviews. Any reference stays honest.
11. Plan the knowledge transfer (KT) from the day the PIP starts: documents, shadowing, a named successor.
12. Agree the leaving date. Offer a send-off, and accept a quiet exit if that is what they prefer.

Within weeks the result is yours, whoever caused it.

Some of the old team leave or are moved out, and you are judged on next quarter's numbers.

S.02

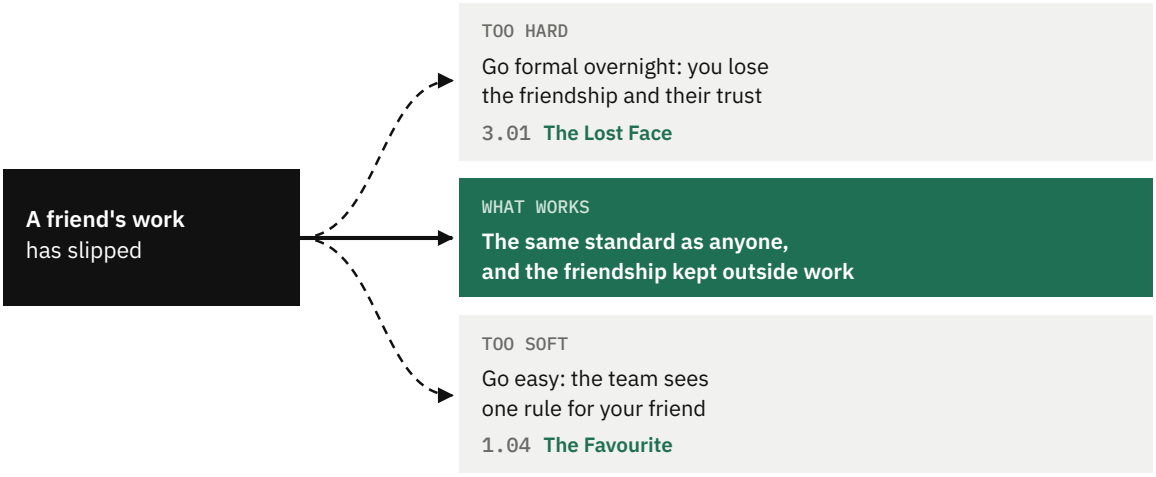
USUALLY: FIX

Your friend is underperforming

You manage someone you're close to: you joined together, or you've been friends for years. Their work has slipped for months, and the team has noticed.

Go easy and the team sees a favourite. Go formal overnight and you lose the friendship and their trust.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Separate the roles

1. Tell your friend directly, one to one: “At work, I have to treat you as I treat everyone.”
2. Be honest with yourself: the friendship may not survive this. Decide now that you will act anyway.
3. Write down the facts of the slip: dates, missed work and the effect on others.

NEXT 6 TO 8 WEEKS
The same chance as anyone

4. Agree written goals, to the same standard as the rest of the team.
5. Give weekly check-ins and straight feedback.
6. If nothing improves, start a PIP with HR, exactly as you would for anyone else.

THEN
Decide

7. If they improve, say so in front of the team.
8. If they don't, follow the same exit path as S.01.
9. Any personal help, such as introductions, happens outside work. Any reference stays honest.

Your friend improves or leaves, and the friendship rarely stays the same.

The team judges you by how you handled it.

S.03

USUALLY: FIX

You inherit a senior's protected underperformer

Someone in your new team is close to a senior leader: a former report, a protégé or a friend. Their work is weak, and everyone knows nobody has dared to raise it.

Challenge it too early and the senior sees an attack. Accept it and the team decides you have no backbone.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

The senior
"leave it alone"
protects them, and hears it from them first

1.06 **No Surprises**

You
inherit the gap, and the blame for it

Your strong people
"deal with it"
decide standards depend on who you know

2.04 **The Quiet Exit**

The person keeps the protection while the gap grows
2.03 **The Protected Colleague**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST MONTH
Build the record

1. Treat them exactly like everyone else: the same goals and the same reviews.
2. Note the facts: dates, deliverables and the effect on others.
3. Find out how close the link really is. People assume more protection than there is.

SECOND MONTH
Tell the senior early

4. Meet the senior before anything formal. Frame it as a heads-up: "I want you to hear this from me."
5. Show the facts and your plan to help. Ask for their view, because they may know already.
6. Brief your own boss at the same time, so nobody is surprised.

THEN
Run the normal process

7. Coach them, then start a PIP if nothing changes, as in S.01.
8. Keep the senior informed at each formal step.
9. If the senior blocks it, raise it with your boss once. If your boss will not back you, you have lost this one for now. Protect the rest of the team and wait for a better moment.

The protected person usually stays, unless their protector moves on.

The manager who pushed too hard often pays for it.

S.04

USUALLY: FIX

Promoted over your former peers

You've been promoted to lead the team you were part of. One colleague also applied for the role, and some of your closest friends now report to you.

Overdo the authority and you lose the team. Stay one of the gang and you can't lead them.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	BEFORE	AFTER YOUR PROMOTION
Your friends	Peers you confide in	**Expect inside treatment** 1.04 **The Favourite**
The other applicant	A colleague	**Resists quietly, to save face** 3.01 **The Lost Face**
The team	Talks freely with you	**Watches for favourites** 2.06 **The Loyalty Test**
Old confidences	Shared with you	**Stop reaching you** 2.05 **The Safe Confidant**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST TWO WEEKS
Reset each relationship

1. Hold a one-to-one with every person, starting with the colleague who also applied. Acknowledge their disappointment, and ask what they want from the next year.
2. Tell your friends plainly what changes: no more talk about the team behind its back, and everyone gets the same treatment.
3. Ask each person what they want you to keep and what they want you to change.

FIRST THREE MONTHS
Be seen to be fair

4. Set the team's goals and ways of working together, so the rules belong to everyone.
5. Hand out good work and stretch tasks openly, and give your reasons.
6. Step back from the team's private chats about management. Build a peer group among other managers instead.

IF SOMEONE KEEPS RESISTING
Act early

7. Talk privately, name the behaviour, and agree what changes.
8. If it continues, treat it as you would any performance issue, with HR.

One or two old friendships cool.

The colleague who also applied often leaves within a year.

S.05

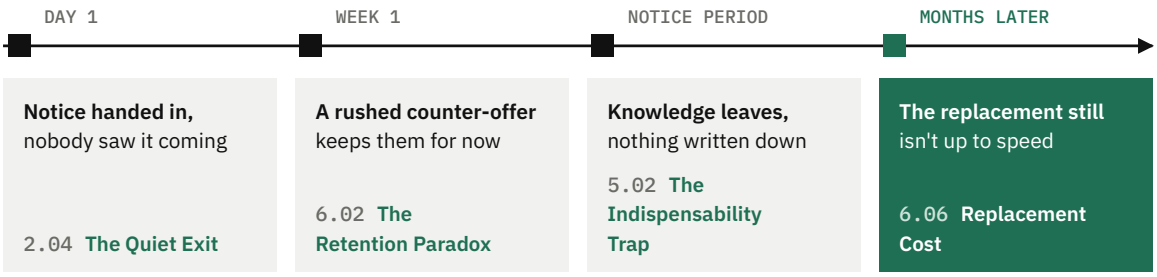
USUALLY: FIX

Your strongest person resigns

Your best performer hands in their notice. They hold key client relationships and know things nobody else does.

Counter-offer in a panic and you reward leaving and upset the team. Let them go without a plan and the damage arrives over months.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

FIRST 48 HOURS
Listen

1. Meet them privately. Ask why they're leaving, and what would have made them stay. Don't argue.
2. Decide with your boss whether to counter-offer. Most who accept one leave within a year anyway, so make one only if the real reason they are going can be fixed.
3. Agree how and when the team and clients are told. Tell them before the rumour does.

NOTICE PERIOD
Protect the work

4. Start the handover plan on day one, whatever happens with a counter-offer: clients, open work, logins, contacts and undocumented know-how.
5. Give each area a named successor, and have that person shadow them now.
6. Introduce the successors to key clients while the person is still there.
7. Start hiring, or arrange an internal move, straight away.

AFTER THEY LEAVE
Learn

8. Part on good terms. Former staff refer people. Leave the door open.
9. Check the team: who else might leave for the same reason? Fix the cause as well as the gap.

They leave. Once someone has resigned, they have mentally gone.

A counter-offer usually only delays it.

S.06

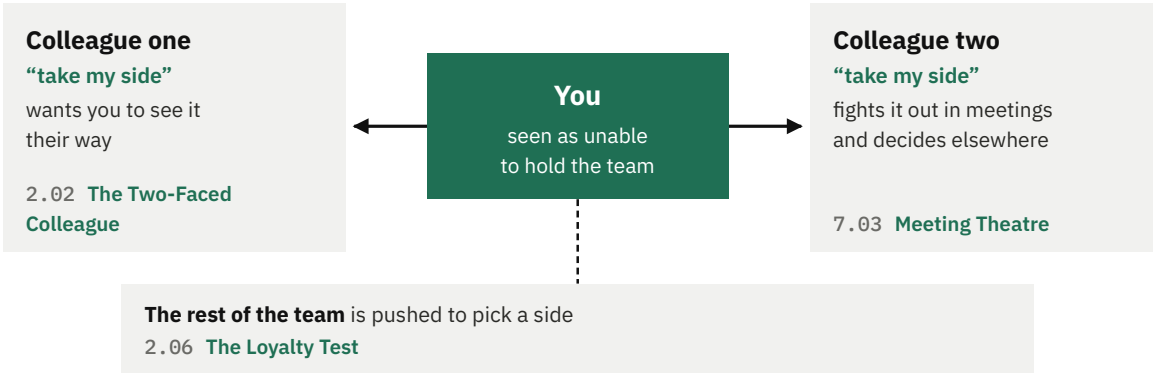
USUALLY: FIX

Two senior team members openly conflict

Two of your most experienced people are openly at odds: sniping in meetings, refusing to share work, each building a camp. Delivery is slowing, and others are taking sides.

Take a side and you deepen the split. Stay neutral and it spreads to the whole team.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

WEEK 1
Hear each side alone

1. Meet each of them privately. Listen fully before you respond. (3.05 Listen First)
2. Separate the work issue (roles, overlap, credit) from the personal friction.
3. Check the facts quietly with others where you can, without turning it into a poll.

WEEKS 2 TO 3
Fix the cause in the open

4. Most of these conflicts start with an unclear split of work or credit. Set out in writing who owns what.
5. Bring the two of them together for one meeting: shared goals, agreed behaviour, and specific examples of what has to stop.
6. Tell the team the new split, so nobody has to choose a side.

THEN
Hold the line

7. Review in four weeks, and acknowledge the change if it happens.
8. If one or both carry on, treat it as a conduct issue: a documented warning with HR and, if needed, a move to another team.

The team sides with whoever the boss seems to favour.

One of the two usually moves teams or leaves.

S.07

USUALLY: FIX

Your predecessor returns and challenges your changes

The person who led the team before you has moved to a senior role nearby. They still talk to your team, and they openly question the changes you've made.

Push back hard and it becomes a contest for status. Give way and the team sees you as temporary.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	WHILE THEY LED	NOW YOU LEAD
The team	Took questions to them	**Still takes them there** 1.07 **The Coterie**
Your predecessor	Built the way of working	**Defends what they built** 7.05 **The Sponsor's Project**
Your changes	Not yet made	**Labelled a mistake** 4.04 **The Sticky Label**
Your boss	Heard from them	**Hears their version first** 1.06 **No Surprises**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Meet them privately

1. Ask for their advice on the history. They know things you don't.
2. Explain what you changed and why. Don't expect it to persuade them.
3. Agree how team questions get handled: they send them back to you.

THEN
Show your results

4. Share what changed and what improved, with numbers, with your boss and the team.
5. Give credit for what your predecessor built and you kept.

IF IT CONTINUES
Use your boss

6. Go to your boss with specific examples: when it happened, what was said, and the effect on the team.
7. Ask your boss to set the boundary, rather than setting it yourself.
8. If your boss will not act, because they are close to your predecessor, accept it. Work round it and keep delivering.

People keep going to whoever they think still has the power.

It stops when your boss backs you openly, or the predecessor moves on.

S.08

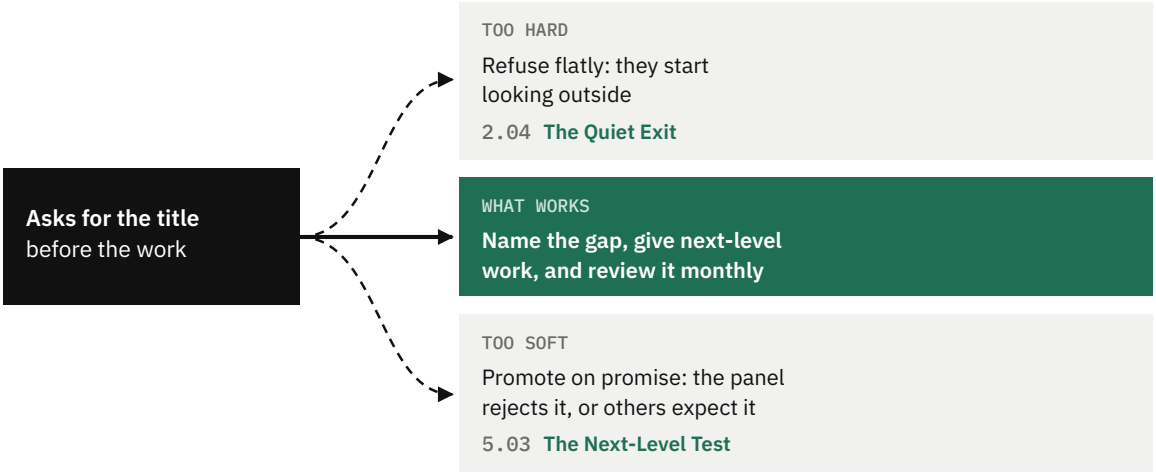
USUALLY: FIX

A high performer asks for the title before doing the work

One of your best people asks to be promoted now. They're strong in their current job but haven't yet done the work of the next level, and they hint they'll leave if it doesn't happen.

Promote on promise and you set a precedent. Refuse flatly and you may lose them.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

IN THE CONVERSATION
Be honest about the gap

1. Thank them for raising it directly.
2. Name the two or three things the next level needs that they haven't shown yet. Avoid vague words like “presence”.

NEXT 3 TO 6 MONTHS
Build the evidence

3. Give them real next-level work: lead a project, handle a demanding client, mentor a junior.
4. Review progress monthly.
5. Put their name in front of the people who decide promotions.

AT THE REVIEW POINT
Decide

6. If they've shown it, argue for them in the room.
7. If no role exists, say so honestly. Never promise a date you do not control.
8. If they leave anyway, part on good terms.

They get the title when someone senior wants them promoted and a budget opens up.

If that doesn't happen, they leave for the title elsewhere.

S.09

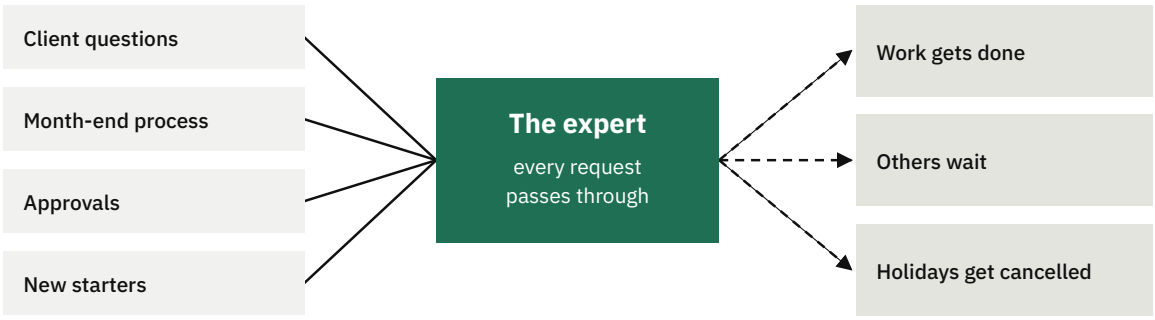
USUALLY: FIX

Your team depends on one person

One person holds a system, process or client relationship that nobody else understands. When they're off, the work stops, and they resist sharing it.

Force the handover and they may leave. Leave it alone and you're one resignation away from a crisis.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



PATTERNS AT WORK

4.05 The Go-To Person

5.02 The Indispensability Trap

6.06 Replacement Cost

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Make it non-negotiable

1. Ask privately why they resist. Often it is fear for their job, and they are partly right: knowledge they hold alone protects them.
2. Tell them plainly that sharing it is now part of the job, and show what they get: holidays without calls, and a path to the next role.

NEXT 2 TO 3 MONTHS
Spread the knowledge

3. Make knowledge sharing part of their goals, with time set aside for it.
4. Pair them with a named backup who shadows first, then does the work while they review it.
5. Write down the critical steps together.
6. Hand the work to the backup for a week as a test.

THEN
Reward it

7. Credit them publicly for teaching the team.
8. Count it in their favour at promotion time.

Nothing changes until you force it, or they leave or fall ill.

Knowledge kept to yourself is job security, and they know it.

S.10

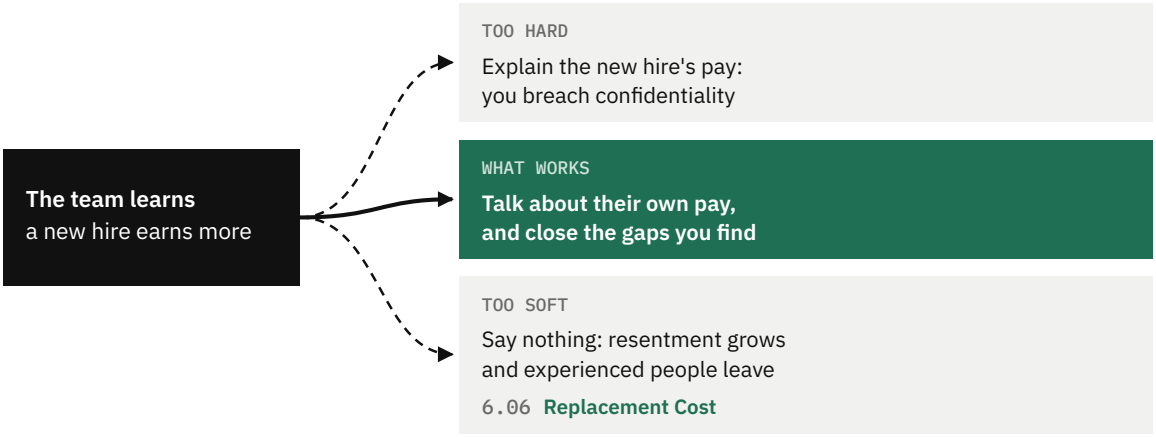
USUALLY: FIX

A new hire earns more than your team

You hire someone at today's market rate, which is more than people who have been on your team for years. Pay information leaks, and the team finds out.

Explain individual pay and you breach confidentiality. Say nothing and resentment spreads.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

BEFORE IT LEAKS

Know the gaps

1. Check your existing team's pay against the market with HR. Know where the gaps are and how big they are.

WHEN SOMEONE RAISES IT

Talk about their pay

2. Don't discuss the new hire's pay. Talk about theirs: where it sits against the market and the role's pay band.
3. Be honest about how pay works here, without excuses.
4. If they're underpaid, tell them what you will push for and when they'll hear. Don't promise the outcome. Pay is rarely the manager's call.

THROUGH THE NEXT PAY ROUND

Close the gaps

5. Push for adjustments for those below market, as well as the standard rises.
6. Tell each person the outcome personally.
7. Protect the new hire from the fallout. They didn't set the rates.

The gap stays until someone threatens to leave.

Then only that person's gap gets fixed.

S.11

USUALLY: FIX

Your person's mistake reaches a customer

Someone on your team made an error that reached a major customer: a wrong invoice, a missed delivery, or data sent to the wrong person. The customer has escalated to senior management.

Defend them before you know the facts and you lose credibility. Distance yourself and you lose their trust, and the team's.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	WHERE IT LANDS
The error reaches a major customer	**Escalation** seniors want one name 8.01 The Scapegoat Mechanism	**The person** is blamed in front of others	**The team** learns to hide the next one 8.02 The Bad News Penalty

WHAT TO DO

FIRST 24 HOURS
Fix it for the customer

1. Own it to the customer as a team: “We got this wrong.” Fix the immediate problem and say when.
2. Tell your boss what happened, what's done and what's next, before they ask.

FIRST WEEK
Find the cause

3. Talk to the person privately: calm first, then facts.
4. Review how the error got through: checks, workload and process. Usually more than one thing failed.
5. Report the cause and the fix to seniors in writing, and take public responsibility as the manager. (8.06 Owned Out Loud)

THEN
Handle the person fairly

6. If it was an honest mistake, coach them and close it.
7. If it was carelessness, or part of a pattern, use the normal performance process, privately.
8. Never discuss it in front of the team.

Seniors remember the name long after the fix.

It stays attached to the error for a while, whatever the cause.

S.12

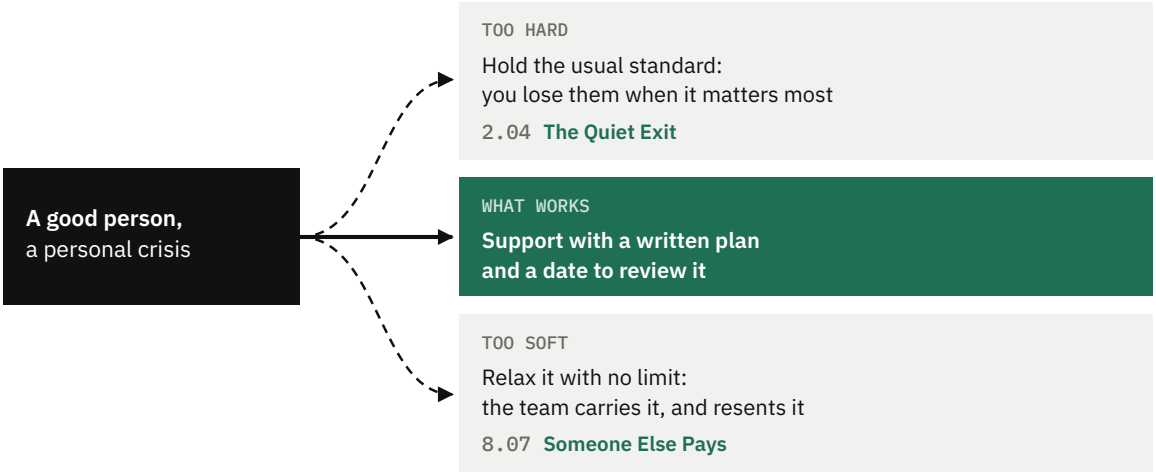
USUALLY: FIX

Someone is struggling because of a personal crisis

A reliable team member starts missing deadlines. Privately, they tell you they're dealing with a serious illness in the family.

Hold the usual standard and you lose them when they need you most. Relax it with no limit and the team carries the load, and resents it.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Listen, then agree a plan

1. Listen without asking for private details. Ask what would help at work.
2. Agree a short-term plan in writing: reduced or moved work, check-in dates, and a date to review it.
3. Check with HR what policy allows: leave, flexible hours, or an employee assistance service.

WHILE IT LASTS
Support and cover

4. Move work to others openly, with a reason the person is happy to share, such as “personal matters”.
5. Thank the people covering, and adjust their own goals to match.
6. Meet weekly. Keep it short and kind.

AT THE REVIEW DATE
Reset

7. If things have settled, return to normal goals and say so.
8. If they haven't, agree the next step with HR: longer leave, a changed role, or a formal plan. Keep their dignity at every step.

Goodwill lasts weeks.

After that, the people covering start to resent it.

S.13

USUALLY: FIGHT

Someone reports misconduct and asks you to tell nobody

A team member tells you a colleague has been harassing them. They ask you to keep it between the two of you, because they fear what will happen if it gets out.

Promise secrecy and you may break policy and leave others at risk. Report it without telling them and you break their trust.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	WHERE IT LANDS
The report comes to you in confidence 2.05 **The Safe Confidant**	**You promise** to tell nobody	**It continues** to them, or to someone else 8.02 **The Bad News Penalty**	**The review** finds you knew and did nothing 8.01 **The Scapegoat Mechanism**

WHAT TO DO

IN THE CONVERSATION
Listen, and promise only what you can

1. Listen fully and thank them for telling you. Don't judge, and don't investigate on the spot.
2. Explain honestly what you can keep confidential, and what policy requires you to report. Never promise total secrecy.
3. Write down what they said, in their words, with the date.

WITHIN A DAY OR TWO
Follow the process

4. Report it to HR through the proper route. Tell the person you're doing so, and why.
5. Ask HR what protection is available: separate work, a changed reporting line, no contact. HR protects the company. It is not there to protect them, so keep pushing until something is actually done.
6. Tell the person they can keep their own dated record, and can get outside advice from a union rep or an employment adviser.
7. Share details only with the people who need to act.

AFTER
Watch for retaliation

8. Check in with the person regularly.
9. Watch for changes in how they're treated: shifts, exclusion, work taken away. Raise any sign at once, in writing.

If the accused is senior or valued, the complaint is often quietly contained.

The person who complained is more likely to be moved than the person accused.

S.14

USUALLY: FIGHT

A high performer who damages the team

Your strongest performer delivers excellent results, but belittles colleagues and keeps key knowledge to themselves. Two good people have asked to move teams.

Tolerate it for the results and the team pays. Act harshly and you risk losing your best performer and their clients.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

Their results
shield the behaviour
2.03 **The Protected Colleague**

Colleagues
are belittled and kept out

Their knowledge
stays with one person
5.02 **The Indispensability Trap**

Good people
ask to move, then leave
2.04 **The Quiet Exit**

You
seen to excuse it for the numbers

Clients
are tied to the star
4.05 **The Go-To Person**

WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Collect examples

1. Write down specific incidents: what was said or done, when, and the effect on others.
2. Talk to the people affected, privately. Ask what happened, rather than what they think of the person.

NEXT MONTH
Name it and agree change

3. Meet them privately. Credit the results, then describe the behaviour and its effect, with examples.
4. Agree two or three specific changes in writing, including sharing knowledge, with a review date.
5. Make how they work with others part of their goals and rating, with HR aware.
6. Pair them with a named backup, so the knowledge spreads.

AT THE REVIEW
Decide

7. If they've changed, say so in their review.
8. If not, start the formal process with HR. Be ready to be overruled, because senior people usually protect a top performer. If that happens, protect the team where you can, and keep a record of what you raised.

They usually stay, as long as the results do.

The people they damage leave.

S.15

USUALLY: FIX

Your predecessor promised someone a promotion

A team member tells you your predecessor promised them a promotion this year. Nothing is in writing, and you don't have the authority or the budget to grant it.

Honour it blindly and you make a promise you can't keep. Dismiss it and you lose their trust in your first months.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	YOUR PREDECESSOR SAID	WHAT YOU CAN ACTUALLY DO
The promotion	"This year, for sure"	**Needs a role, a budget and a panel** 6.04 **The Vacancy Lottery**
The record	Spoken, never written	**Nothing to point to** 8.08 **The Inherited Result**
The person	Trusted the old boss	**Tests whether to trust you** 1.02 **The New Boss Reset**
The panel	Not asked	**Backs who a senior backs** 5.03 **The Next-Level Test**

WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Find out what was said

1. Ask them what exactly was promised, when, and by whom. Thank them for raising it.
2. Check with your predecessor, your boss and HR what was agreed, if anything.

WITHIN A MONTH
Give a straight answer

3. Tell them what you found, honestly, even if nothing was recorded.
4. Explain the real promotion criteria and who decides. (5.03 The Next-Level Test)
5. Agree what they need to show, and when you will argue for them.

THEN
Keep your own word

6. Review it monthly.
7. Argue for them in the room when they're ready, and find them a senior backer.

The promise leaves with the person who made it.

Unless you give them a real path, they often leave within the year.

S.16

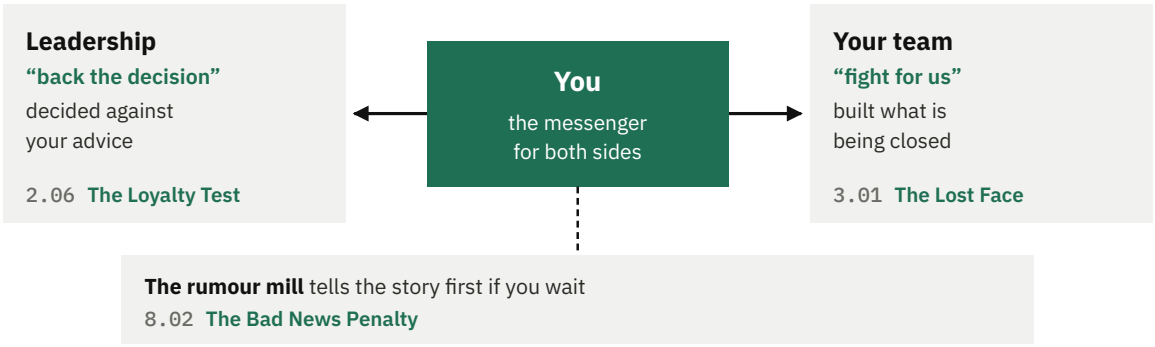
USUALLY: FIX

You must announce a decision you disagree with

Leadership decides to close a product your team built, against your advice. You have to tell the team on Monday.

Disown the decision and you undermine leadership and look powerless. Sell it as your own and the team stops believing you.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU ANNOUNCE
Prepare

1. Ask your boss for the reasons you can share, and what is still open.
2. Raise your concerns with your boss once more, privately. Then accept the decision.
3. Prepare honest answers to the hardest questions, including “did you agree?”

THE ANNOUNCEMENT
Tell it straight

4. Tell the team yourself, in person, before they hear it elsewhere.
5. Explain what was decided, why, and what happens next. Say clearly what is final and what isn't.
6. Acknowledge the work that went into what is closing.

AFTER
Carry it through

7. Hold one-to-ones with the people most affected.
8. Take the team's concerns back to leadership, and report the answers.

The decision stands, and you are expected to look as if you agree.

The team judges you by how straight you were with them.

S.17

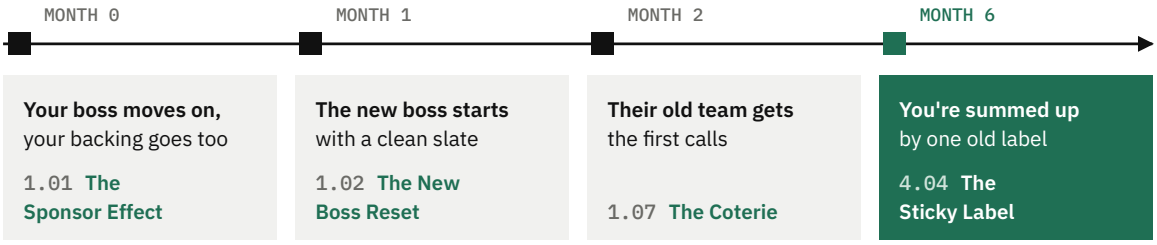
USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

Your boss leaves, and the new one brings their own people

Your boss, who backed you for years, moves on. The new boss arrives with two people from their last team, and decisions start to happen in a circle you're not part of.

Fight for the old arrangement and you look like the past. Detach too quickly and you lose relationships you still need.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

FIRST TWO WEEKS

Meet the new boss early

1. Ask for a one-to-one in the first week. Ask what they need to succeed this year.
2. Bring a short written summary: what you own, what's going well, what's at risk, with numbers.
3. Offer help with their first priorities. Don't talk down the old regime.

FIRST THREE MONTHS

Earn a new record

4. Deliver one result on their priority, early, where they can see it.
5. Build a working relationship with their incoming people. They will shape what the boss hears.
6. Keep in touch with your old boss. They are your best reference.

FROM THE START

Keep your options open

7. Ask your boss directly what they need from you before giving you more scope.
8. Start looking quietly, inside and outside the company, from the first month. New bosses decide early who stays close.

The new boss's own people come first.

Within six to twelve months the inner circle is theirs, and people outside it often leave.

S.18

USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

Passed over after strong results

You had a strong year and expected the promotion. Someone else got it, and the feedback was vague: “not quite ready”.

Demand credit for the past and you look bitter. Accept it quietly and the same thing happens next year.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	WHAT YOU COUNTED ON	WHAT THE DECISION RAN ON
Your results	A strong year →	**Proof of this level only** 5.03 **The Next-Level Test**
Your boss	Praised you →	**May prefer you where you are** 5.01 **The Rising Star Penalty**
Your mentor	Encouraged you →	**Was not in the room** 5.04 **Mentor, No Sponsor**
The role	Seemed open →	**One budgeted slot, now gone** 6.04 **The Vacancy Lottery**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST WEEK
Stay calm and ask

1. Congratulate the person who got it, in person.
2. Ask your boss for specific feedback. Notice what they avoid saying.
3. Don't argue the decision. Collect the facts.

NEXT 3 TO 6 MONTHS
Close the gaps where it counts

4. Agree a plan with your boss: next-level work, a date, and how you'll be judged.
5. Find out who argued for the person who got it. That is who you need on your side.
6. Train a successor for your current job, so moving you costs nothing.

AT THE NEXT ROUND
Decide

7. If the gaps are closed and nothing moves, ask plainly what is stopping it.
8. “Not quite ready” usually means “not my pick”. If the answer is vague again, take that as your answer. (5.05 The External Reset)
9. Look outside from the start, so you are not choosing in a hurry.

The promotion went to whoever had someone senior arguing for them.

Closing your gaps rarely changes the next round. A sponsor or a move does.

S.19

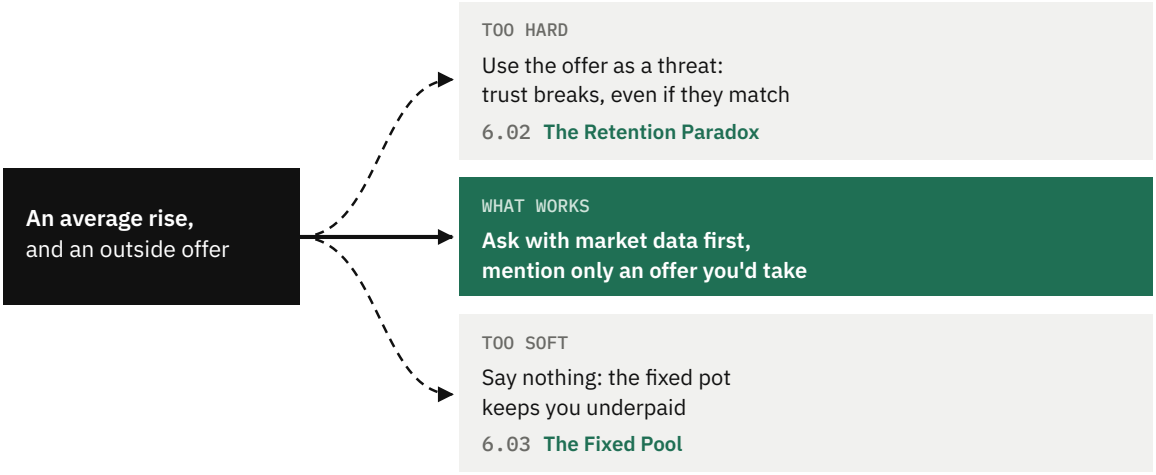
USUALLY: FIGHT OR LEAVE

A great year, an average rise and an outside offer

You had your best year, and your rise was the same as everyone's. Then a recruiter offers you a role elsewhere at 25% more.

Use the offer as a threat and you damage trust. Say nothing and you stay underpaid.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU TALK
Know your number

1. Check the market: two or three similar roles, and what they pay.
2. Decide what you actually want: pay, title, scope or a move. Know your walk-away point.

THE CONVERSATION
Ask without threatening

3. Ask your boss for a pay review, with market data, before mentioning any offer.
4. Explain your results and your market value. Ask what is possible and by when.
5. Mention a real offer only if you are ready to accept it.

THEN
Decide

6. If they match, take it only if the reason you looked is fixed. After a counter-offer, your manager will treat you as someone who will leave.
7. If you leave, give proper notice, a full handover and a good goodbye.

Most companies match pay only when you are already halfway out of the door.

People who stay get the standard rise.

S.20

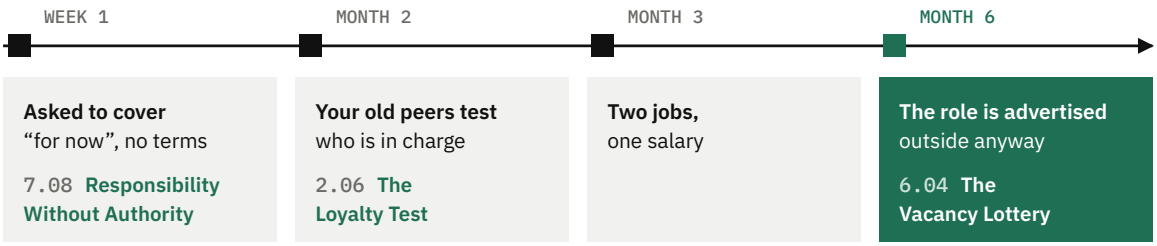
USUALLY: FIX

Asked to act up for your boss

Your boss leaves or goes on long leave, and you're asked to cover their job “for now”. There is no date, no pay change, and no word on whether the role will be advertised.

Take it on with no terms and it becomes free work. Demand certainty and you lose the chance.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU SAY YES
Agree the terms

1. Ask for the terms: a review date, what you can decide, and any acting allowance. If they won't write it down, send your own short email: “As agreed today…”
2. Ask whether the role will be advertised, and whether you can apply.
3. Agree who covers your old work.

WHILE YOU ACT
Do the job

4. Make the decisions the role needs. Check the big ones with your boss's boss.
5. Tell the team clearly what you're covering and for how long.
6. Keep a record of the results and the decisions you've made.

AT THE REVIEW DATE
Close it out

7. Ask for the decision: made permanent, a fair process, or a clear end date.
8. If it ends, hand back cleanly and ask your boss to tell their boss what you delivered.

The role often goes to someone else, or you stay “acting” for months at the same pay.

S.21

USUALLY: FIX

You join a new company in a senior role

You join a new organisation as a senior hire. People already have their alliances, and a few of them hoped for your job.

Change things before you have trust and you meet resistance. Wait too long and others decide who you are.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

The existing team
reads you through your first moves
1.02 **The New Boss Reset**

The inner circle
makes decisions you don't see
1.07 **The Coterie**

Real decisions
happen before the meeting
7.01 **The Pre-Meeting**

Internal candidates
who wanted the job may resist quietly
3.01 **The Lost Face**

You
an outsider with a title and no allies

Your track record
impresses at first, then fades
4.07 **Borrowed Credibility**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST 30 DAYS
Listen and map

1. Meet every direct report and key peer one to one. Ask what works, what doesn't, and who you should talk to.
2. Meet the people who wanted your job. Acknowledge it, and give them a real role.
3. Find out how decisions actually get made, and by whom.

DAYS 31 TO 60
Quick fixes

4. Fix one or two problems everyone already agrees on.
5. Share a short written view of what you've found and what you plan, and invite challenge.

DAYS 61 TO 90
Your changes

6. Agree your priorities with your boss.
7. Make the bigger changes, with the allies you've built.
8. Keep talking to the people who disagree.

People decide who you are in the first 90 days, and it sticks.

If the inner circle isn't with you by then, they wait you out.

S.22

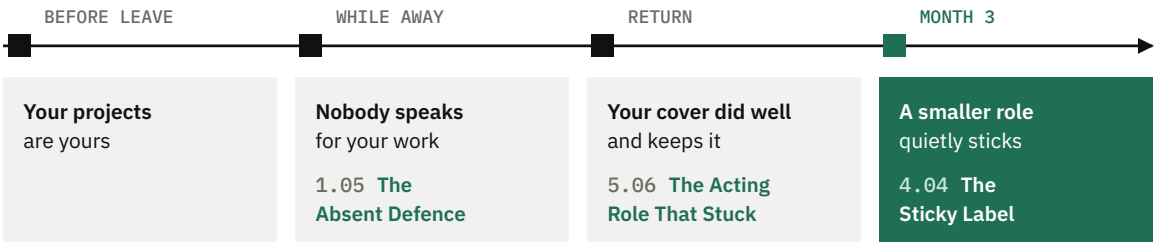
USUALLY: FIGHT

You return from long leave and your role has moved

You come back from long leave: parental, medical or a career break. Your projects were reassigned, the person who covered wants to keep them, and your role looks smaller.

Demand everything back and you look difficult. Accept less without testing it and it becomes permanent.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU RETURN
Prepare

1. Ask your boss for a return meeting before your first day.
2. Know your rights on returning to the same or a similar role before that meeting. If parts of your role were cut, get outside advice early.

FIRST MONTH
Agree the role

3. Ask plainly what your role is now, and what changed while you were away.
4. Thank your cover and recognise what they did, in front of others.
5. Agree in writing which work comes back to you and when.

THEN
Get noticed again

6. Deliver one result early that people notice.
7. Re-introduce yourself to the people your work depends on.
8. If the role is materially smaller, put it in writing to your boss and HR, and get advice before you accept it.

What someone else held while you were away is now theirs.

Unless you push back in the first month, the smaller role becomes permanent.

S.23

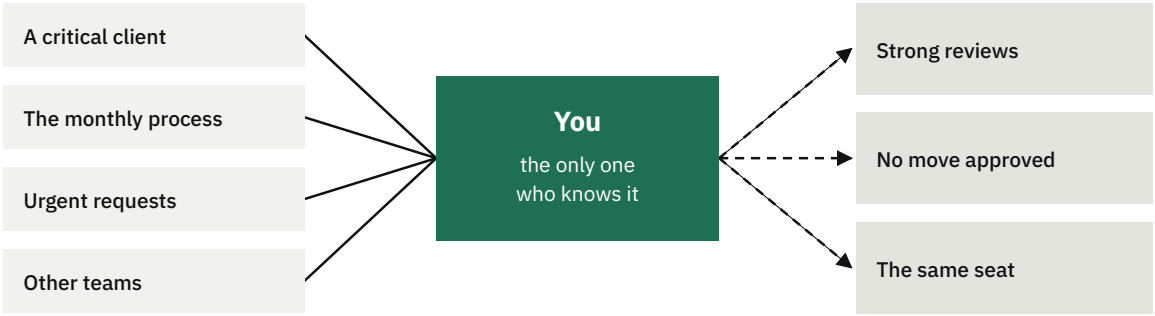
USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

You're indispensable, and it's keeping you stuck

You're the person everyone relies on for a critical process or client. Your reviews are strong, but your boss blocks every internal move: “We can't spare you.”

Threaten to leave and you damage the relationship. Stay useful and you stay invisible.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



PATTERNS AT WORK

- 5.02 The Indispensability Trap
- 4.05 The Go-To Person
- 4.04 The Sticky Label

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Make yourself replaceable

1. Write down how the critical work is done.
2. Train a named backup until they can do it without you.
3. Take a full holiday as the test.

THEN
Ask for the move

4. Tell your boss what you want next, with a date, and how the work will be covered.
5. Ask a sponsor elsewhere to argue for you.

IF IT'S STILL BLOCKED
Decide

6. Going over your boss's head usually costs you the relationship. Do it only if you are ready to move on anyway.
7. The real answer is usually an offer elsewhere. Look inside and outside the company, and leave with a full handover.

Your boss blocks every move until you have an offer they can't block.

S.24

USUALLY: FIX

A failure with your name on it

A project you led failed in public: it missed the launch, lost a client, or went far over budget. Your name is now attached to it.

Over-explain and you look defensive. Say too little and others tell the story.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3	WHERE IT LANDS
The failure is public and talked about	**The review** needs one name to close it 8.01 The Scapegoat Mechanism	**The numbers** travel without their context 4.06 The Number Speaks	**Your name** becomes the label for the failure 4.04 The Sticky Label

WHAT TO DO

FIRST WEEK
Own it

1. Say clearly what went wrong and what part was yours, with no excuses. (8.06 Owned Out Loud)
2. Fix what can still be fixed for customers.
3. Protect your team in public. Handle their part privately.

FIRST MONTH
Learn in writing

4. Write a short review: causes, decisions, and what you would do differently.
5. Keep your own record of who approved what, and when. Someone will be blamed, and the record decides who.
6. Share the review with your boss and the people affected.

NEXT SIX MONTHS
Rebuild the record

7. Take on a project you can deliver well, and make sure the right people see the result.
8. Use the lessons openly. People remember how you recovered.

Your name stays linked to the failure for a year or two.

Recovery comes from a visible success somewhere else.

S.25

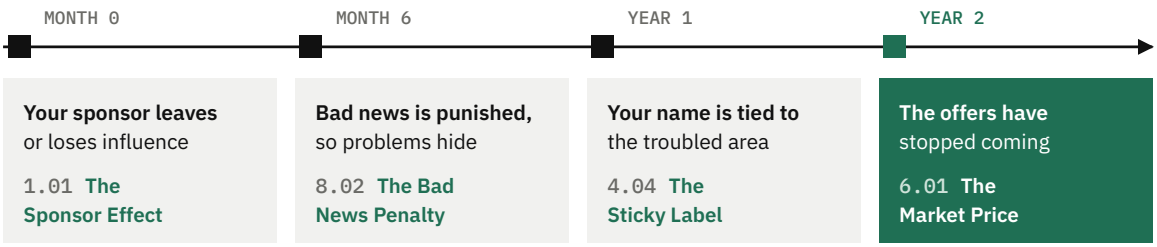
USUALLY: LEAVE

Stay and repair, or leave

Your organisation is struggling: repeated reorganisations, a lost sponsor, a reputation that won't move. You're tied to the problems, and offers are coming in.

Leave too early and you abandon something you could fix. Stay too long and your reputation sinks with it.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Test whether it can change

1. List what would need to change for you to stay, and by when.
2. Ask your boss and a senior sponsor directly whether those changes are coming.

NEXT THREE MONTHS
Stay, and look

3. Do your best work where you are, and keep your results ready for your CV.
4. Talk to the market quietly: what roles, what pay, and what you would be known for.

THEN
Decide

5. If the changes have started, commit and say so.
6. If not, leave well: a full handover, a proper goodbye, and no burned bridges.

Struggling areas rarely turn round fast, and your reputation goes with the area.

People who stay too long often leave later, on worse terms.

S.26

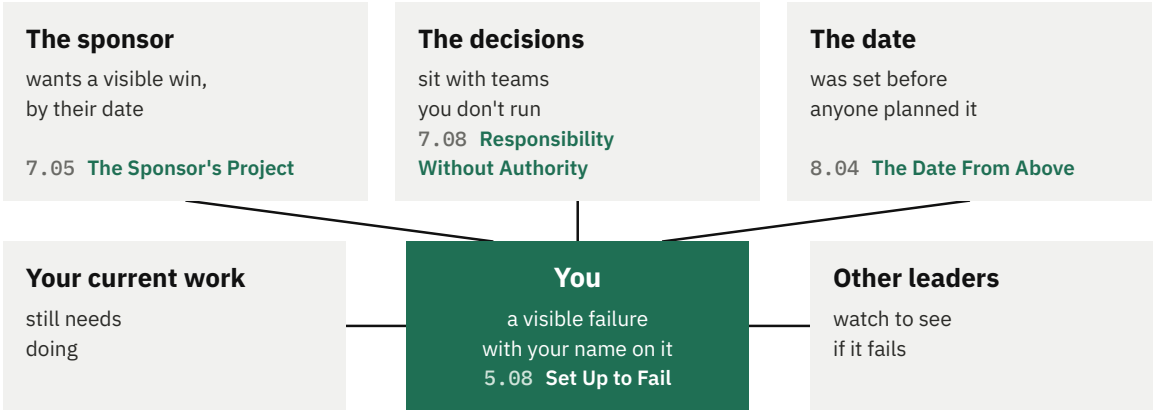
USUALLY: FIX

Offered a high-profile project with no authority

A senior leader offers you a high-profile initiative. It would be great for your career, but the date is unrealistic and the key decisions sit with other teams.

Say yes with no conditions and you risk being set up to fail. Say no and you may not be offered the next one.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU SAY YES
Ask the questions

1. Ask what success looks like, who decides, and what resources come with it.
2. List what you need from other teams, and who owns each part.
3. Ask for the authority you need. If nobody writes it down, send your own email afterwards: “As agreed, I can decide…”

IF YOU TAKE IT
Put the risks in writing

4. Write down the assumptions the date depends on, and share them with the sponsor.
5. Report progress and blocked decisions every week.
6. Agree in advance what happens if another team's part slips: the date, the scope or the resources.

IF THE ANSWERS ARE POOR
Negotiate

7. Offer a smaller first phase you can deliver.
8. If nothing changes, decline politely, with the risks set out in writing.

If the decisions sit with others, you carry the failure and they keep the credit.

S.27

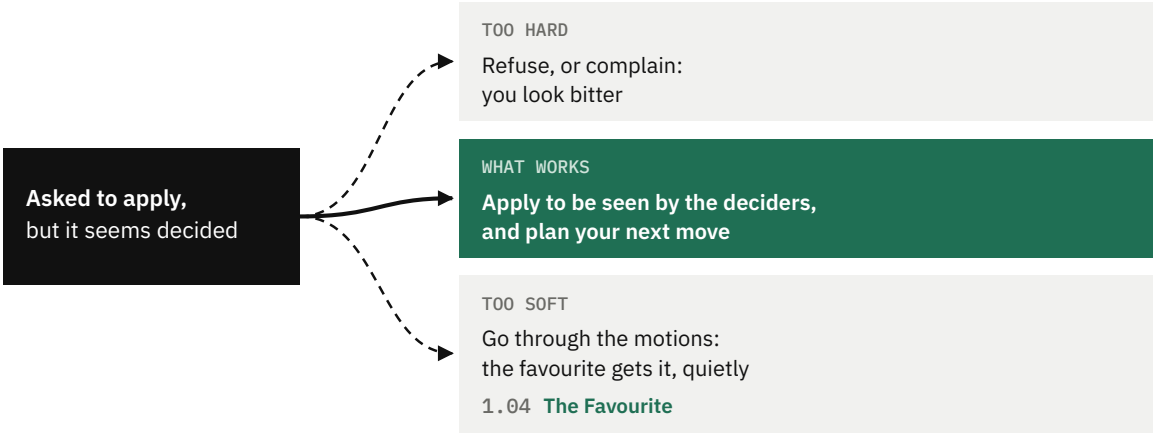
USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

Asked to apply for a role that seems already decided

A role opens above you, and you're encouraged to apply. Then your manager hints it has already gone to someone else.

Refuse or complain and you look bitter. Go through the motions and you waste the chance to be seen.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

BEFORE YOU APPLY
Ask directly

1. Ask the hiring manager for the criteria and the timeline.
2. Ask whether there is a preferred candidate. You will rarely get a straight answer, so watch who is already doing the job unofficially.

IF YOU APPLY
Use it well

3. Prepare properly anyway.
4. Treat the interview as a chance to be seen by the deciders.
5. Ask for feedback afterwards. Expect it to be vague.

AFTER
Plan the next one

6. Ask the deciders for specific feedback.
7. If it was decided before you applied, accept that this round is gone. Decide whether there is a future here, or start looking.

The favourite gets the job.

Applying only gets you seen.

S.28

USUALLY: FIGHT, THEN LEAVE

Your team merges, and only one lead role remains

Your team is merged with another. There will be one lead role, and you and the other lead both want it.

Fight openly and you split both teams. Step back and you lose the role by default.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	TWO LEADS	ONE LEAD ROLE
You	Lead your own team	**Compete for one role** 8.05 **The Cut List**
The other lead	Leads their own team	**Competes, with their own circle** 1.07 **The Coterie**
Both teams	Loyal to their lead	**Watch who wins** 2.06 **The Loyalty Test**
Whoever loses	Kept their title	**Loses face, and may leave** 3.01 **The Lost Face**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Find out how it will be decided

1. Find out who decides, and how close the other lead is to them.
2. Keep leading your team well. Results help, but the decider's trust decides.

DURING THE DECISION
Compete fairly

3. Make your case to the deciders with results and a plan for the merged team.
4. Work properly with the other lead, and never run them down.
5. Keep your team informed of what you know.

AFTER
Either way, act well

6. If you get it, give the other lead a real role and public credit.
7. If you don't get it, expect it to feel like a demotion. Agree your new role in writing, or plan your exit. (5.05 The External Reset)

The lead closer to the decider usually wins.

The one who loses usually leaves within the year.

S.29

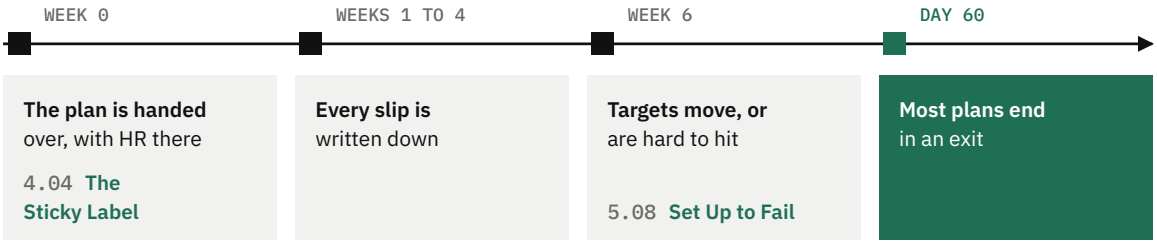
USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

You're put on a performance improvement plan

Your manager calls a meeting with HR and hands you a performance improvement plan: targets, a review in 60 days, and a warning that failing it can end your job.

Fight it head on and you confirm their view. Accept it quietly and hope, and you may be out of work in two months with nothing lined up.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

DAY ONE
Read it, don't sign in the room

1. Listen, take the document, and ask for time to read it. HR is in the room to protect the company. You don't have to agree on the spot.
2. Ask what specifically fell short, with examples and dates, and write down the answers.
3. Check whether the targets are measurable and possible in the time given.

FIRST WEEK
Protect yourself

4. Start your own dated notes: every meeting, what was said, and what you delivered.
5. Keep copies of earlier praise, feedback and results, within company policy.
6. If the plan looks unfair, or linked to something else such as recent leave or a complaint you made, get outside advice from a union rep or an employment adviser.
7. Reply in writing to correct anything inaccurate, calmly and briefly.

THE 60 DAYS
Run two tracks

8. Hit every target you can, and send your manager a short weekly email of what you delivered.
9. Start looking for your next role at the same time. Most people on a plan leave, whatever happens.
10. If you find a role first, negotiate your exit: notice, a reference, and an agreed reason for leaving.

By the time you're on a plan, the decision is usually made.

Most people on a plan leave, at the end of it or before.

S.30

USUALLY: LEAVE

You're being managed out without a word

Your best work is reassigned, you are left out of meetings you used to lead, and your manager has gone quiet. Nobody has raised a performance problem.

Confront it angrily and you give them a reason. Ignore it and you find out when the role is cut.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	SIX MONTHS AGO		NOW
Your work	The main client account	→	**Routine tasks only** 4.04 **The Sticky Label**
Meetings	You led the weekly review	→	**You hear about it afterwards** 1.04 **The Favourite**
Your manager	Regular one-to-ones	→	**Cancelled, or cut short**
Your name	On the plans	→	**Missing from the new structure** 8.05 **The Cut List**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST TWO WEEKS
Check it is real

1. List the changes with dates: work moved, meetings dropped, one-to-ones cancelled.
2. Ask one trusted colleague what they are hearing. Don't ask around widely.

THEN
Ask directly, once

3. Ask your manager in a one-to-one: “My work has changed a lot. Is there a problem with my performance or my role?”
4. Send a short email afterwards that sums up what was said.
5. If the answer is vague, treat it as a yes.

ALONGSIDE
Protect yourself and move

6. Keep your own dated record and copies of your results, within policy.
7. Start looking, inside and outside the company, now.
8. If a restructure or an exit offer comes, get outside advice before you sign anything. HR protects the company, so its first offer is the company's offer. Exit terms can often be negotiated.

Nobody tells you. They take your work away and wait for you to go.

Unless you move first, a restructure or a quiet exit offer follows.

S.31

USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

You work remotely and keep getting passed over

You work from home most of the week and deliver everything on time. The new projects and the last promotion went to people who sit near the boss.

Complain and you sound bitter about a policy everyone accepted. Say nothing and you stay out of sight until the next restructure.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



The good work goes to whoever is in front of them.

PATTERNS AT WORK

- 4.10 Out of Sight
- 7.09 The After-Hours Circle
- 5.12 The Head Office Advantage

WHAT TO DO

FIRST MONTH
Get seen on purpose

1. Come in on the days your boss and the deciders are in, even if your team isn't.
2. Send your boss a short weekly note of what you delivered and what is next.
3. Ask for one piece of work that puts you in front of senior people.

NEXT THREE MONTHS
Ask directly

4. Ask your boss what the people who got the projects did that you didn't. Notice what they avoid saying.
5. If being in the office decides it, decide whether the flexibility is worth what it costs your career.

THEN
Decide

6. If nothing changes, look for a company where remote staff do get promoted. Ask at interview who was promoted last year, and where they work.

The work and the promotions go to whoever the boss sees most.

Remote staff are the first to be forgotten, and often the first on the cut list.

S.32

USUALLY: FIX

Two executives want opposite outcomes from your project

Your project has two senior sponsors. One wants it fast and cheap, and the other wants it complete. Each tells you privately that their view is the priority.

Pick one and you lose the other. Try to please both and you deliver neither.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

Executive one
"my view first"
wants it fast
and cheap

7.05 **The Sponsor's Project**

You
blamed by whoever
didn't get their way

Executive two
"my view first"
wants it complete,
and agreed it privately

7.01 **The Pre-Meeting**

Your team pays for the conflict in rework
8.07 **Someone Else Pays**

WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Put both views on paper

1. Write down both positions side by side: the scope, cost, date and risk of each.
2. Show each sponsor the other's view, so nobody is surprised later.

NEXT TWO WEEKS
Get one decision

3. Ask both sponsors, together, to choose. Offer two or three clear options.
4. If they can't agree, ask the person they both report to for a decision.

THEN
Hold to it

5. Record the decision and share it with the team and everyone affected.
6. When either sponsor asks for a change, show the trade-off against the agreed decision.

The more senior, or better connected, sponsor wins.

The other one blames the project.

S.33

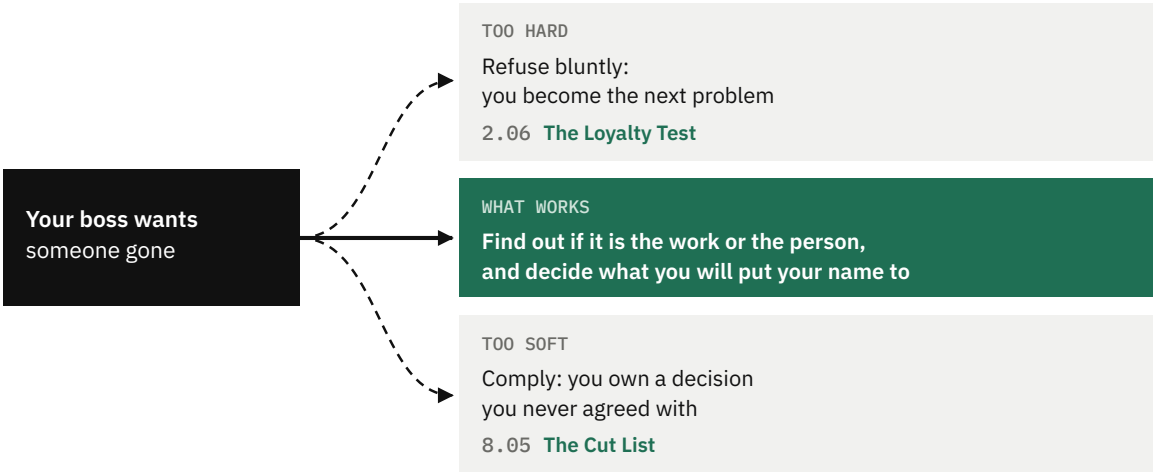
USUALLY: FIGHT OR LEAVE

Your boss asks you to remove someone they dislike

Your boss tells you to “manage out” someone on your team. You don't see a performance problem, and the reason seems personal.

Comply and you own an unfair decision. Refuse bluntly and you become the next problem.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

IN THE CONVERSATION
Find out what this is

1. Ask your boss what is behind it. Listen for whether it is about the work or the person.
2. Tell them plainly what you see in the person's work.

NEXT FEW WEEKS
Decide your part

3. Handle a real performance problem the same way you would for anyone (S.01, steps 4 to 7).
4. If it is personal, say once that you don't see a performance problem.
5. Expect the exit to happen anyway, by restructure, role change or settlement.

IF YOUR BOSS INSISTS
Protect yourself

6. If you are asked to give a reason you know is false, refuse that part. Expect it to cost you.
7. Keep your own dated notes. They matter if this ends in a legal claim.
8. Decide whether you can keep working for this boss.

They usually go: a restructure, a role change or a settlement, often with no performance evidence.

If you refuse, it happens without you, and your boss remembers.

S.34

USUALLY: FIGHT

A senior asks you to keep a serious risk off the report

You have found a serious risk: a delay, a cost overrun or a compliance gap. A senior leader asks you to leave it off the status report “until we know more”.

Refuse without tact and you damage the relationship. Agree and you share the blame when it surfaces.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

SAME DAY

Understand the request

1. Ask what they're worried about. Sometimes it is the timing. Sometimes they want it hidden. Find out which.
2. Offer an honest version: the risk, what's being done, and when you'll know more.

BEFORE THE REPORT GOES

Agree the wording

3. Agree wording that is accurate and calm: the risk, the owner and the next step.
4. If they still want it removed, send your own short email afterwards: what was agreed, and when it will be reported.

IF THEY INSIST

Raise it safely

5. If it is serious, raise it with your own boss or the company's speak-up route. People who raise problems often pay for it, so keep your own record.
6. Keep your own record of what you knew and when.

The risk often surfaces anyway.

Whoever knew and stayed quiet shares the blame.

S.35

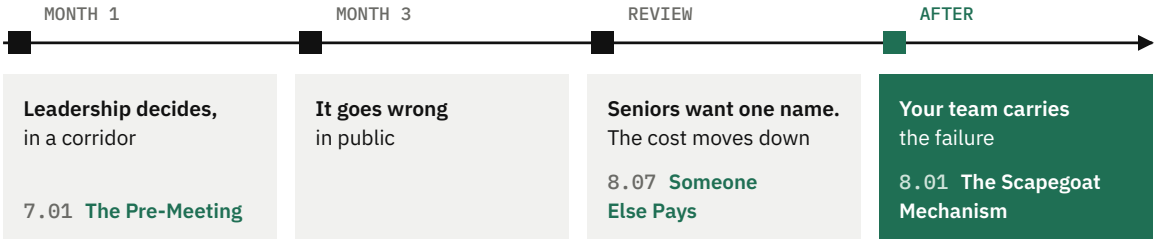
USUALLY: FIX

Your team is blamed for a decision made above it

Leadership made a call: a cut, a shortcut, a rushed date. It went wrong, and now your team is being blamed for the outcome.

Expose the senior in public and you make an enemy. Absorb the blame and it sticks to your team.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Get the facts straight

1. Gather the record: who decided what, when, and with what information.
2. Fix what you can for customers first.

THEN
Correct the record privately

3. Show your boss the timeline and the decision trail, calmly, without accusing anyone.
4. Tell your boss privately who decided. Don't expect it to be said in public.

WITH YOUR TEAM
Protect them

5. Tell your team you've raised it, and that their work is not being judged on this.
6. From now on, get key decisions confirmed in writing.

Blame flows down, and the team carries it.

The record rarely clears in public.

S.36

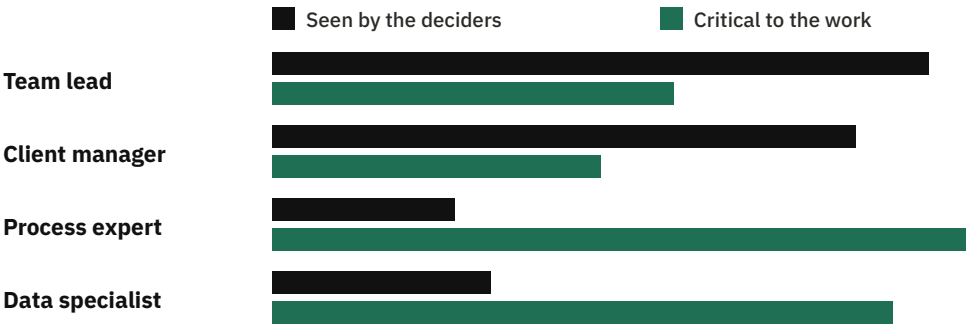
USUALLY: FIX

You must cut two roles and keep the work running

Every team has been told to cut costs by 15%, and for yours that means two people this quarter. The obvious cuts would remove the people who quietly keep a critical process running.

Cut the people nobody senior notices and you lose hidden expertise. Protect everyone and you miss the target, and someone else chooses.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



Cut lists follow the dark bars. The work depends on the green ones.

PATTERNS AT WORK

8.05 The Cut List

6.06 Replacement Cost

6.05 The Cost-Centre Penalty

WHAT TO DO

FIRST TWO WEEKS
Choose fairly

1. Map the work: what's critical, who can do it, and what can stop.
2. Expect names to come from above. Argue for the people the work depends on, with what breaks without them.
3. You will probably lose at least one of them.
4. Check the legal and policy steps with HR before telling anyone.

TELLING PEOPLE
Do it with care

5. Tell each affected person yourself, privately, with HR present, before any announcement.
6. Offer what policy allows: notice, support, redeployment options and time to look for work.
7. Help them personally: a referral, introductions, and an honest reference within policy.

AFTER
Keep the team working

8. Arrange a proper KT before they leave.
9. Tell the remaining team what changes, who now owns what, and what stops.
10. Drop or delay work the smaller team can't carry.

The people the deciders know are the last to be cut.

At least one person the work depends on usually goes.

S.37

USUALLY: FIX

Two teams are merged under you

Two teams with different habits, tools and status are merged, and you lead the result. Each side expects its own way to win.

Standardise fast and you alienate one side. Keep both ways and the split lasts for years.

IF YOU DO NOTHING

	TWO TEAMS	MERGED UNDER YOU
Team one	Its own habits and tools	**A camp inside the new team** 1.07 **The Coterie**
Team two	Its own habits and tools	**Watches which side you favour** 2.06 **The Loyalty Test**
The way that loses	How one team worked	**Its people lose face** 3.01 **The Lost Face**
Budget holders	Funded each team	**Protect the stronger one** 6.07 **The Protected Team**

WHAT TO DO

FIRST MONTH
Learn both

1. Hold one-to-ones with everyone in both teams. Ask what works in their way and what doesn't.
2. Name the duplicated roles honestly. Uncertainty does more harm than bad news.

MONTHS TWO AND THREE
Choose by evidence

3. For each process, pick the better way and give the reasons. The losing side will still see favouritism.
4. Mix people from both sides on shared work.
5. Keep one or two things from each side that people value.

THEN
One team

6. Set shared goals and measure the whole team on them.
7. If roles must go, follow the steps in S.36.

The side with the more powerful boss keeps its way of working.

Some of the other side leave.

S.38

USUALLY: FIGHT

More output, an earlier date, and the same people

Leadership raises the target and brings the deadline forward, and sales has promised a customer extra work from your team. There are no extra people or budget, and your team is already working late.

Promise it and you burn out the team. Refuse and you look incapable.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



The gap of 400 hours lands on the same people.

PATTERNS AT WORK

- 6.09 The Target Ratchet
- 8.04 The Date From Above
- 7.08 Responsibility Without Authority

WHAT TO DO

THIS WEEK
Do the maths

1. Count the hours the new target needs against the hours your team has. Write it down.
2. List what's already committed, and what would have to stop.

NEXT MEETING
Offer choices

3. Show leadership the gap, with numbers.
4. Offer two or three options: less scope, a later date, more people, or stopping other work.
5. Ask them to choose. If they say “do it all”, email what you will deliver by the date and what will not happen. If nobody replies, that is their choice.

THEN
Protect the team

6. Track progress weekly against the agreed option, in the open.
7. Raise the alarm early if the plan slips. (1.06 No Surprises)
8. Watch for burnout: overtime, sick days, people going quiet.

Leadership rarely chooses, and targets go up when you hit them.

The team absorbs it until people burn out or leave.

S.39

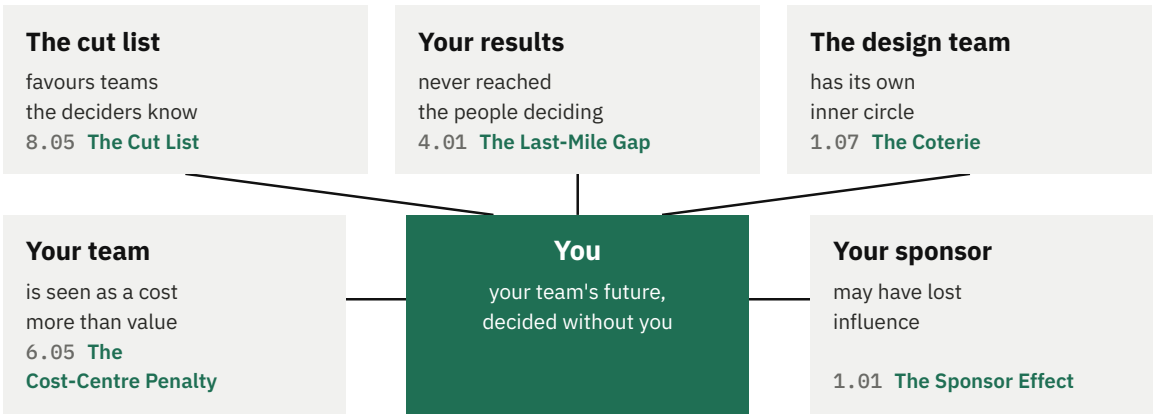
USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

A restructure puts your team or role at risk

A reorganisation is announced. Your team's future is unclear, the new design is being drawn by people who barely know your work, and rumours fill the gap.

Campaign loudly and you look self-interested. Stay quiet and the design is fixed without you.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

FIRST WEEK

Find out who decides

1. Ask your boss who is designing the new structure, and when decisions are due.
2. Keep your team informed with what you know, and say what you don't.

BEFORE THE DESIGN IS FIXED

Show what your team delivers

3. Send the designers a one-page summary: what your team delivers, with numbers, and what breaks without it.
4. Ask a sponsor to put it in front of the decision makers.
5. It is probably already decided, sometimes by outside consultants. Update your CV the same week, quietly.

WHEN IT'S ANNOUNCED

Look after people

6. Tell your team the outcome yourself, as soon as you're allowed.
7. If people are affected, follow S.36. If your own role goes, ask for the same care.

By the time it's announced, it's done.

Teams with a senior voice in the room come out best.

S.40

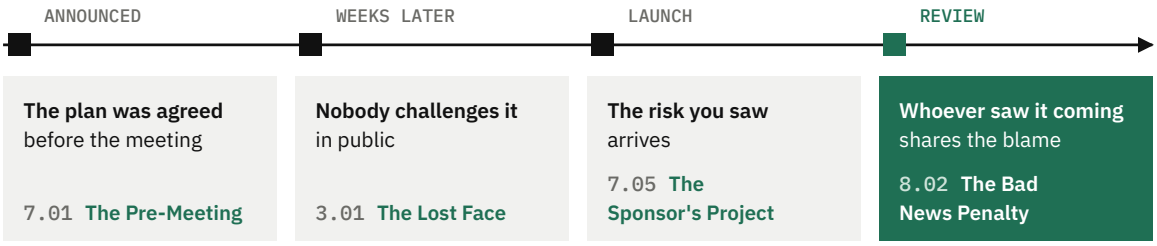
USUALLY: FIX

You believe a senior's plan will fail

A senior leader has announced a plan you believe will fail: the costs are wrong, or a key risk is ignored. Others agree privately, and nobody says it.

Challenge it bluntly in public and they lose face. Soften it until it disappears and you share the failure.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



GREEN: WHERE IT ENDS UP. DARK: WHAT HAPPENS ON THE WAY.

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Check your case

1. Test your view with numbers. Ask one or two trusted people to challenge it.
2. Find out what the senior is trying to achieve. You may share the goal.

THEN
Raise it privately

3. Ask for time one to one. Start with their goal, then show the risk.
4. Bring a fix with the problem: a pilot, a check point, or a change of scope.
5. Listen to their answer fully. They may know something you don't. (3.05 Listen First)

IF IT GOES AHEAD
Protect the outcome

6. Ask for a review point where the risk will be checked.
7. Record your concern once, in writing, calmly.
8. Then help make it work.

The plan goes ahead. Seniors rarely change a plan they have announced.

People who warned early are rarely thanked, even when they were right.

S.41

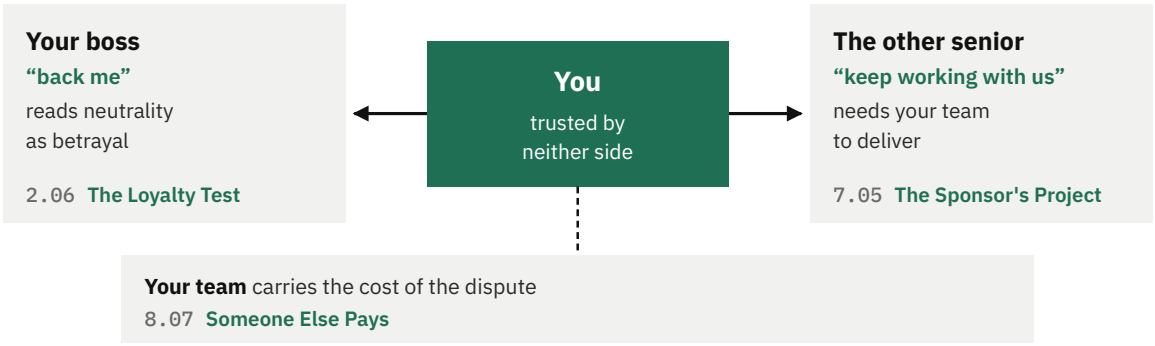
USUALLY: FIX

Your boss wants your loyalty in a dispute between seniors

Your boss is in a dispute with another senior leader. They want you to back them in meetings, and to stop working closely with the other side.

Take sides too early and you inherit their enemies. Stay out and your boss sees you as disloyal.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

IN THE CONVERSATION
Back the work

1. Tell your boss you'll support their goals and back the facts in meetings.
2. Explain that your team still needs to work with the other side to deliver.

DAY TO DAY
Stay useful to both

3. Keep working relationships with the other team professional, and in the open.
4. Stick to facts in meetings. Don't repeat what one side says about the other.
5. Keep your boss informed of contact with the other side, so nothing surprises them.

IF IT GETS WORSE
Get clarity

6. Ask your boss what outcome they need, and how you can help without harming delivery.
7. If you're asked to do something unfair, say no calmly. Going over your boss's head is a last resort, and usually ends the relationship.

Your boss's enemies become your enemies.

Whichever senior wins, the people seen on the other side lose out.

S.42

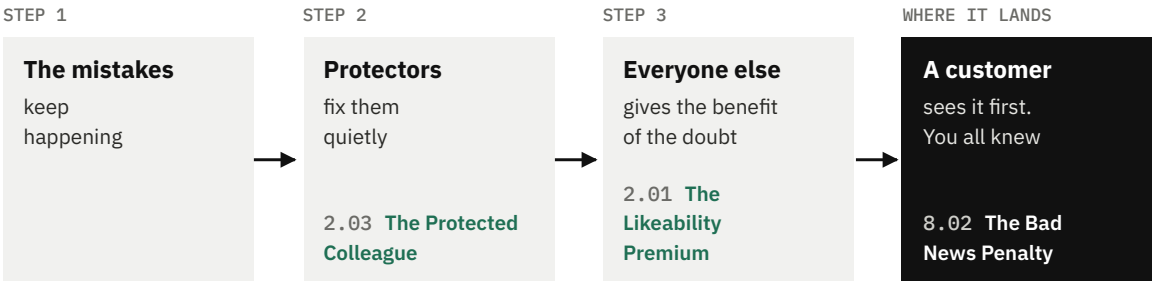
USUALLY: FIGHT

A respected senior's mistakes are being covered up

A well-liked senior colleague keeps making serious mistakes, and others quietly fix them. People admire them, and nobody wants to be the one to raise it.

Escalate hard and you look disrespectful. Stay quiet and you share in the cover-up.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Check and record

1. Note the facts: what went wrong, when, and the effect. No gossip.
2. Check whether anyone has already raised it.

THEN
Speak to them

3. If you can, talk to the person privately, with respect. Ask if they're all right.
4. Offer help. Mistakes sometimes come from overload, health, or a role that changed.

IF IT CONTINUES
Raise it properly

5. Take it to your manager or theirs, with the facts.
6. If it affects customers, safety or compliance, use the formal speak-up route.
7. Stop covering the errors. Fix them openly, and record who fixed what.

It continues until a customer or an outsider sees it.

Then the people who covered get blamed too.

S.43

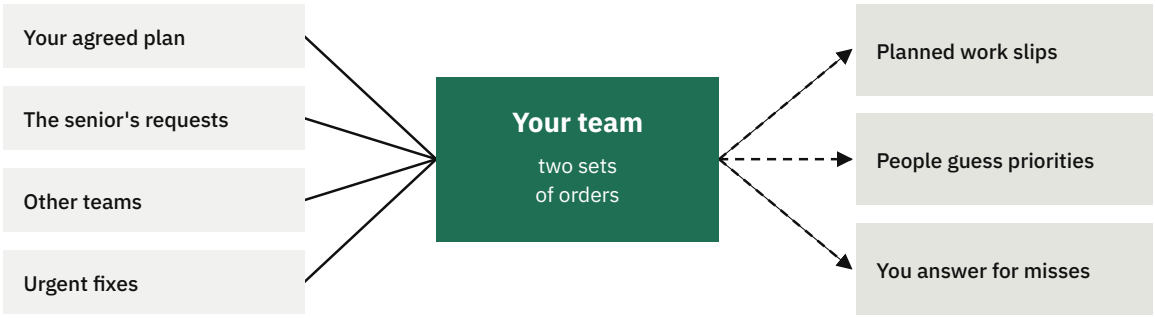
USUALLY: FIX

A senior bypasses you and directs your team

A senior leader keeps giving your team work directly, skipping you. Your planned work slips, and you are still held to the original dates.

Complain about the senior and you make a powerful enemy. Let it continue and you're accountable for a plan you no longer control.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



PATTERNS AT WORK

- 7.08 Responsibility Without Authority
- 7.07 The Default Decision
- 8.01 The Scapegoat Mechanism

WHAT TO DO

FIRST
Talk to the senior

1. Ask to meet the senior.
2. Show what their requests displaced, with dates and effects.
3. Ask them to send requests through you, so you can say what moves.

THEN
Show what gets displaced

4. Keep one list of your team's work and priorities, visible to all.
5. Log each direct request and what it pushed back.
6. Tell your team that anything from outside comes to you first, and you will handle the conversation.

IF IT CONTINUES
Settle who decides

7. Ask your boss to agree with the senior who sets your team's priorities.
8. If nothing changes, log each request and report what it displaced, every week. Let the numbers make the case.

It continues while it works for the senior.

Your boss rarely stops someone more senior.

S.44

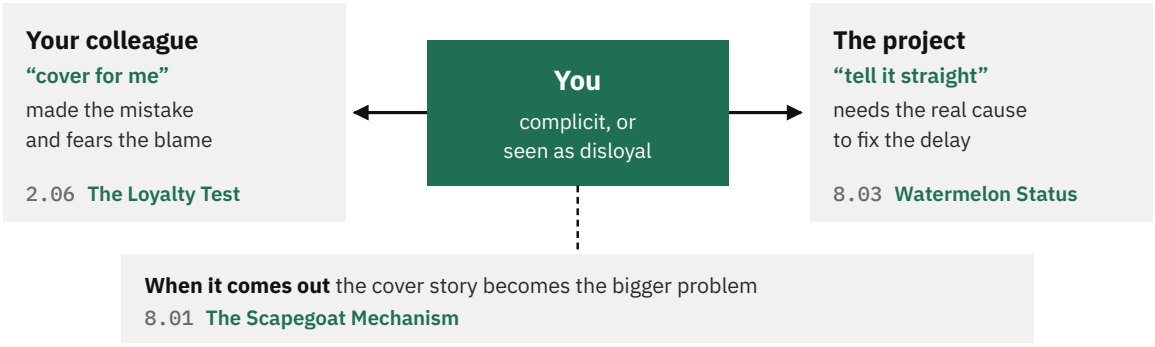
USUALLY: FIX

A colleague asks you to cover for their mistake

A colleague missed a deadline that delayed a shared project. They ask you to tell the project lead it was caused by a supplier delay.

Cover for them and you share the false story. Expose them bluntly and you lose a working relationship.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



WHAT TO DO

IN THE CONVERSATION
Say no, and offer help

1. Tell them you can't give a false reason, and why: when it comes out, you are both hurt.
2. Offer to help them explain what happened and what will fix it.

SAME DAY
Help them own it

3. Help them write a short, honest update: the cause, the effect and the recovery plan.
4. Suggest they tell the project lead themselves, before anyone else does. (8.06 Owned Out Loud)

IF THEY REFUSE
Give the facts

5. Give the project lead the accurate cause and the recovery plan, without comment on the person.
6. Keep working with them normally afterwards.

The real cause usually comes out, and both stories get checked.

Covering for a colleague makes you part of it.

S.45

USUALLY: FIX, THEN LEAVE

You're the most expensive person on the team, and cuts are coming

A cost review has been announced. You have been there twelve years, you are the best-paid person on your team, and two cheaper people could cover most of what you do.

Assume your experience protects you and you can be caught out. Panic and look for jobs openly, and you speed up the decision.

IF YOU DO NOTHING



On a spreadsheet, you look like two people.

PATTERNS AT WORK

8.10 The Expensive Target

8.05 The Cut List

5.10 The Age Filter

WHAT TO DO

NOW

See yourself as they will

1. Work out what you cost, and who could cover your work if you went. That is the sum the deciders will do.
2. Find out who is running the review, and how close your boss is to it.

BEFORE THE LIST IS DRAWN

Make losing you look costly

3. Put in front of your boss what breaks without you: clients, knowledge, and work nobody else can do.
4. Take on something critical to next year, where losing you would hurt someone senior.
5. Get your CV ready and talk to the market quietly.

IF YOU ARE ON THE LIST

Get the best exit

6. Get outside advice before you sign anything. The first offer is rarely the final one.
7. Negotiate notice, money, a reference and the timing of your leaving.

The best-paid people go first, whatever their performance.

Experience protects you only if losing it would visibly hurt someone senior.

Most surprises at work have a reason behind them. Once you know the reason, you see the next one coming.

THE SERIES

BOOK 1

Framework Thinking

How to think through a problem: name it, understand it, decide, bring people along.

BOOK 2

Kaizen Practice

How a team runs and improves its daily work, one routine at a time.

BOOK 3

Hidden Logic

Why things happen between people at work, and what to watch for.

Sanjay Chandra
Global CoE Community

76 PATTERNS
45 SCENARIOS
8 PARTS